Carry on, Catra!!!

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/53284543.

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General Audiences

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra), He-Man | Adam/Teela

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Part 4 of CATRA AND GREYSKULL

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Carry on, Catra!!!

by the_Frank

Summary

After the events of last book, Adora S.Greyskull and her trusted Catra has taken up residency in New York, until things have cooled down back in old England.
But it doesn't take long for things to start buzzing, as Adora's twin brother, Adam, shows up with a whole beehive in the bonnet. He needs to get married before his 25th birthday or he won't get the money he needs! And so, he turns to his beloved sister for her help.
Unfortunately, Aunt Sharon has a few opinions about this affair , not to mention what Uncle Howard (Lord Ordac) has to say about it... And I say, it will require all the fish-eating skills of Catra to bring this whole affair to a suitable ending!

Art by MUSTLOVEFROGS.

Notes

Wow... It has been ages, hasn't it? Yeah... I began to write this three ago, but couldn't find the right motivation to finish it until somewhere around november. But here it is!!! FINALLY!!!

I think you are familliar with the gang, and if you're not, just start with the first part of the series!

Part 1

CARRY ON, CATRA!

by

THE FRANK



Catra and Adora S. Greyskull

To get you in the mood.

Part 1

New York really is the city of cities! It is indeed a place, where a girl can really have three days on the town and a side dish of morning in a single night! Well, not to brag about my socialistic abilities, but I sure had had just one of those, three in a row even, if I don't miscalculate.

1 - 2-3, No I didn't!

Well, it was after the thirdish of these nights it all began. It had been one slick of a jumper, that night, I say! It began at two with cocktails with Binky, proceeded to a variety at five, a sip of champagne at seven at Poppys place, dinner at eight at that place on that street what's it's name again ah well it's not important, dancing on the tables with Binky at ten - not at the same restaurant though -, discussing the opportunities for Russia with a bearded man at eleven thirty, another dinner at one, sharing a cab with three people I could swear was my friends from oxford but turned out to be german tourists at two and cocktails at three again. And somewhere around sometime after that variety dancer had been drinking brandy from Binky's hat I think I lost my stockings.

…Who the devil is Binky?

Well, anyway, somewhere between the closing of the subway and the first paper boy began to disturb the sleep of honest people, I rumbled into the rooms we rented, prepared to rouse Catra up from her beauty sleep to give me some H&E combined with her patented solution for curing the old copperbeater. However, she was sound asleep and looked so peaceful that I couldn't bring myself to it. Instead I sneaked into the kitchen to steal myself one or two of the emergency sandwiches we keep for moments like

this. I would have killed for a cup of tea, but I have promised Catra on the life of my nephews NEVER to touch a gas cooker while well-oiled again. So a Tonic water from the refrigerator had to do.

As you may have experienced, sometimes the odd cocktail makes you slightly weepy and nostalgic. I began to think about my old life in back in the old country… Dear old england! Dear old white cliffs of Dover, dear old Tipperary! Dear old Coventry, dear old Brighton, where a gal could have almost as fun as here… And dear old London, where I slept in my dear old lair in my dear old bed with my dear ol… dear Catra. I began to shiver a bit, I would say that it felt kind off lonely and cold all of a sudden! I may have been a bit buzzed, but I recognize the old devil homesickness anywhere I see it! I say, had the opportunity occurred, I would have ran straight down to the docks and bought a ticket, but… since the events considering my ex-fiancee, it was to early to return. Aunt Sharon had not cooled down enough (A letter from Glimmer said that she was still "practically fuming") so as hard as it was on an Londoners heart, I had to stay in the big apple, like a worm waiting to become a butterfly. …Or is that Larvae? Anyway, there was at least one thing I could do to get my mind off! I could just go back to the old new bed and lay down next to Catra. I pray that she wouldn't change! I strolled out towards the bedroom again. Where she lay, still sound asleep. My Catra. My treasure. My knight. My… yes… ehrm. anyway!

Unfortunately I have to admit that in my slightly sozzled estate, I had completely forgotten where the old bedroom was!

I kept strolling around the rooms, and while it was maybe the third or fourth time we rented these rooms, I couldn't for my life remember where to turn to reach the bedroom! I had passed the landmarks way too many times now. There were the dreadful oil paintings of a meadow in New Jersey, there was a copperstick of the statue of liberty, there was the coatrack that I had to make sure not to bump into again… Finally as I opened the right door

on a whim, I found myself in the living room. Satisfied with at least having reached some familiar ground I stayed a second to look out the French windows to greet the new morning. Like they say in that one song, dum dum da dum… Mornings! You know the one, right? I say, at least the living room began to grow on me! The view, the atmosphere… even the smell! I decided that even if I couldn't find Catra, the sofa would be good enough to rest my weary feet or whatever the poet said.

I turned around to take in the room as it slowly lit up with the rose fingered Eos fingers. (B+ in Greek litterature!) There was the table, there was the cocktail tray, there was the sofa, there was me asleep on it.

I had to rub my eyes, but there it was. I looked one time, two times, three times, but it was me! The blonde hair, the smoking, the red lipstick. I frowned. How had I managed to go to sleep without noticing? But if I was sleeping on the sofa, who was I then? Catra? But I had seen her asleep on her bed when I got in! This was becoming too much for me, and while a gentlewoman must always be a gentlewoman, there are times when you have to take extraordinary measures! I ran out of the room, opening every door until I found the room where Catra was. I ran in and grabbed what I thought was her and began to shake her awake.

"Catra! Catra! Catra! Wake up!" When she didn't react, I shook her even more, almost screaming. "CATRA" Then I heard a well know voice behind me.

"Miss Greyskull, what is the matter? And may I inquire why you are shaking my pillow?"

I slowly turned to find Catra, fully dressed and wearing an apron, ready to begin the day. I stared at her while I opened and closed my mouth for a second, and then it all came back to me. "Catra!" I cried, "who am I?"

"I… beg your pardon miss?"

"Who am I, I said!?" With some sharpness this time.

"You are miss Adora Swordhand Greyskull, miss, daughter of the late Earl Rancor Greyskull and…"

I instantly bit her off, partly because do know my family and Catra can and will recite it up to the seventh generation if not stopped, "Are you sure!?"

"...Yes, miss Greyskull?"

"But… But *I* was sleeping on the sofa last night!"

"...I believe you were out on the town with some friends last night, miss?"

"That may so be, but I have still been sleeping on the sofa! I am sleeping there right now! But I can't very well be sleeping, can I?" Catra gave me a worried glance, took a careful step forward and took my hand.

"Miss Greyskull… did you by any chance try anything stronger than a cocktail last night? Perhaps a small pill or a white powder…?"

I sweaped her hand away, and jumped three feet back (I really did! I have strong legs.) with indignation.

"CATRA!" I exclaimed. "I am not making up C&B stories! As I rumbled in last night, there you were in bed, there was I in the kitchen and there I was AGAIN on the sofa! Now, I can't be in two places at once, can I?"

Catra gave me another worried look as she seemed to be torn between different emotions. I could barely hide my excitement, to hear her explanation for this! Finally she spoke with great concern in her voice.

"Miss Greyskull… you didn't try to make tea, did you?"

"Catra! Really! I have been sleeping in two places and THAT is what you get your unmentionables in a jiffy about?"

"No, I *didn't* ," I added After a rather poignant look. "I remember last time and I am not going through that mess with the insurance company again! Look, I get the feeling that you are not taking this matter very seriously!"

"Miss, I assure you…"

"And don't try to give me that old buzz about a 'natural explanation' Catra! I may have been a bit spiffed but my eyes were as trustworthy as they are now! I will show you!"

I ran out to the living room, still in my smoking. I must say that I am happy that I didn't do some sort of exclamation they always do in movies, you know the kind, 'Lady Teazle, by all that's wonderful!" Or "There you have it, officer! That's a dead body if I've ever seen one!" because I would have swallowed that whole. I stood there mouth wide as Catra entered. The sofa was empty.

"Miss Greyskull?"

"Eh...eh...eh...eh...Sofa!" I couldn't get a single word out!

"Indeed, miss."

"B...b...b...I… I…"

"Miss Greyskull, please calm down, you are upset. May I suggest you sit down, or even lay down. I will get you some tea and perhaps a…"

I didn't want tea, I was going mad! Cold water! Cold water in the face, that was the only cure, not a drop of tea or brandy! But as I opened the bathroom door, *there I was again* ! I was sure, I would recognize myself anywhere! Long blond hair, white smoking shirt and black trousers, (the jacket hung over the chair you don't

name). As I turned around to look at myself, I noticed I had wiped the lipstick off my lips and now I had begun… Shaving?

I stared at myself with fear and confusion, I looked back at myself with… well more annoyance than anything. I raised my hand and tried to talk but again words refused to leave my mouth. I didn't speak either. Then Catra materialized behind me.

"Lord Greyskull arrived rather late last night, Miss. I took the liberty to offer him a place to rest for the night and then breakfast and a chance to freshen up before he spoke to you."

That was too much for me and the world went black. I remember a faint yell, "ADORA!" and "SIS!" and then I was out.

When I awoke I was laying on my bed, wearing a rather nice peach coloured dress, and silk stockings. (How Catra manages to do that without waking me baffles me every time.)

Next to the bed was a plate with a few sandwiches and a steaming cup of tea. I was not convinced that I had not been dreaming, or if I still was or whatever the hay was happening. But the tea and sandwiches felt and tasted real enough. Catra always buys real butter when we're in the states, and that taste is something I will recognize anywhere! After devouring them I left the bedroom to find Catra and the other me that wasn't me waiting for me, amiably chatting. It's funny, what a difference a cup of tea makes to the mind! Any rainy morning can be turned into a sunny and charming day with a nice, steaming cup at your bedside table!

For me, the cup cleared the mists of yesterday and now I saw the truth as it was.

The other me was definitely not me, but my brother, Adam Greyskull. Lord Greyskull the fifth, if we are to be precise.

Since I haven’t really had the chance to introduce you formally to him, I can tell you that we are twins (I am the oldest), and as such we are quite the lookers both of us. I do have to say that he is a bit of an airhead but he is nice and pleasant enough. We grow up as two peas in the same pod, and when we weren't at school, we spent all holidays competing against each other. Rugby, arching, cross country running, horsing, fencing… I think I am in the lead by two points nowadays, but we don’t have the time to meet as often as before.

As I entered, he rose from his chair (All 5 ft. 7 of him. He’s grown since last time!)



“Adora!”

Well, what do you answer to that? Only one thing I say!

“Adam!”

Tow hich he replied.

“Adora!”

To which I replied, with some gusto since he obviously was going for it,

“ADAM!”

Abot that Time, Catra decided to make her voice heard with a discreet cough.

“Miss Greyskulll? Lord Greyskull?”

“YES?/Yes?”

“Perhaps a more polite greeting would be in place, Miss Greyskull?”

You can always trust Catra to take control of the situation.

“Oh! Oh yes! Jolly good to see you, bro! But what brings you to the new world? And to the big apple, I mean, you can barely stand London unless it’s a sunday.”

“Ah! Well… you see… This is most embarrassing. I had to see you, you know. And I only learned a forthnite ago where you were staying and… well, business and all that had to be dealt with so I couldn’t come here until yesterday.”

“I believe, your lordship, that miss Greyskull was wondering what reason you had to come here.”

“Ah! Ah yes! Yes. Well, Adora. You see, I am in the most bally hobble. It’s pretty rummy, at least sort off.”

"My dear Adam, say no more! You are at the right place for rummy business! I mean… If you need to open your heart to lay the troubles in the old kit bag, this is the best place for it! Catra, can you refill the nose-bags for us and get us some more tea? This sounds like something you don't discuss on an empty stomach!"

Catra nodded and unmaterialized from the room. I refused to let Addie say anything about his troubles until we had the H&E steaming in front of us. Hard troubles always goes best with breakfast I say!

As Catra reappeared and we sat down to inhale the food, I did a slight reflection about how curouisly the world could spin sometimes. As I think I said… No, I didn't did I? As I didn't say, me and Adam don't see each other as often these days. Since we both came of age, he being a man and all, became the lord Greyskull. Therefore he *should* be the one living in a huge London Villa or a big estate and deal with the family business, and I should live in the country knitting kittens and petting sweaters and all that. But we don't, I live… You know where I live, and while we still *own* castle Greyskull, no one lives there. It's huge and old and cold and looks like a skull. Adam lives where ever he lays his hat (currently Essex) because while I love the old beehive, he can't stand London for more than a few months at the time. He travels the world 'pretending' to look after the family business (On paper I should as well, at least Aunt Sharon keeps telling me that. But why should I? We have good accountants and they give me an envelope on how much money I have on my account every month anyway!) but in reality, he writes books. Under some pen name I can never remember, he is the author of the minor successful series about He-Man and the Masters of the universe. I haven't read them, save for the occasional glance to know what the latest title is, mostly cause they seem a bit dull and slightly too much muscles, tanned skin and overadverbic fight scenes, but men are now and forever small boys.

As I had reached that point in my rumination, he had finished his eggs and spoke up. Catra gave him a look, she thinks Adam eats

with a plobbyness unworthy of a gentleman. (She sometimes thinks the same about me but I am trying at least.)

“Adora! I need to get married!”

I must say, that was a surprise. Not that he has found someone, Adam is a hopeless romantic. I can’t see where he got that from. But, he is a kind-hearted soul so there was nothing to do but congratulate him!

"Oh! Well, congratulations then!"

"No! It's a disaster! I don't want to!"

“Really? Hm. Bummer. Why not? Is the lady not cute enough or have you finally decided you actually prefer boys?

"Adora, you know I can’t possibly make that choice!?”

“Well, I guess you have to, since you are getting married and the laws are still as bally un-understanding as always?”

“...Alright, yes. But that is not the problem, and I didn’t say I *was* getting married. I said that I *had* to get married!”

I had the question on my tongue, but I didn’t need to put it in two words. I knew instantly the reason. Aunt Sharon.

You see, it's pretty simple. When there is something afoot that has a slight pernicious angle to it, you can always count on aunt Sharon being either involved or the instigator.

Imagine my surprise then, when he shook his head.

“No. It’s uncle Howard.”

I think you could see my surprise from a mile away. We are not quite sure how Uncle Howard became part of the family because compared to me and Adam (And the little we remember of father) he seems like an anomaly. And even if Aunt Sharon is scary,she

has an energy and at least some kind of force to drive herself forward. Unfortunately, by forcing others to pull her, but at least it's there. Uncle Howard (Or Lord Ordac as he's formally known, he has some sort of foreign ancestry) is sitting in his home doing nothing but brooding and watching his money grow. His only passion in life is chemistry and we see very little of him.

That meant that Adams next words led to Catra having to close my mouth.

"He summoned me to Alarum Court a month ago."

Alarum court, or "the sacred sanctum of solitude" as we used to call it as kids has been Uncle Howards home for as long as I have known. It lies surprisingly beautiful and as far away from everything as possible in the middle of Dartmoor. The closest town is Exeter, I think that says it all.

"...Wha?"

"Yes, my words exactly! Well, I was served a nourishing but extremely grey lunch, Veal stew, cheese pie and wild cherry compote, and there was not a single drop of brandy to go with the coffee. And Uncle Howard didn't say a word to me during the whole meal. It wasn't until we had finished the coffee that he finally said something."

"What did he say then?"

"Hmpf."

"Excuse me for asking!"

"No, Dor. That was what he said. 'Hmpf'."

"Oh."

"Yeah. Then he lit his pipe, so I figured that at least I could light a cigarette to clear the mood. And there we sat, smoking. Finally, he spoke. 'Adam. I hold no illusions that you find this conference as

dreading as I do.'. I protested of course but he cut me off. 'No reason to lie, boy. I do not like you, I find your presence disturbing my work. But unfortunately it is my duty as the oldest in the family to make sure your fathers wish can be fulfilled.' I said 'what' and he just gave me a cold look. 'Mr Grizzlor. Please bring me the will. And a glass of lemon water.' You remember his valet?"

"Oh yes! I remember. Didn't he look like he was covered in fur?"

"Yeah… He did. And does.. Anyway, he came back with the paper and the water for Uncle. Nothing for me, but he did give me an ashtray. Anyway, uncle Howard cleared his throat and said, 'As you well know, the title and the estate Greyskull is Fidie. The money, however…' He cleared his throat again '...Ah yes. After a few legacies and some breadcrumbs to servants, and 100 000 £ to your sister…' Here he drew a deep breath, 'To my son Adam Shieldfist Greyskull, I give him an immediate legacy of 150 000 £ and the rest of my fortune, 450 000 pounds should befall on him on his 25th birthday. However.' He paused and gave me a look of purest opprobriousness, 'as I want the family to prevail and make sure that the name greyskull stays prominent in britain, should he NOT be married within six months of his 25th birthday, he will only get 50 000 £ and the rest shall go to another benefactor. I have called you here to make sure that happens.' 'What, you want me to be married' I said. 'No, I don't. Frankly, I prefer to see you as far away as possible, but it is my duty to at least inform you about this. And now I have. Get out of my house before the clock strikes two or I will send the dogs after you.' Well, I instantly realized I need your support in this matter, and I went straight to London."

"Straight to London? Adam, even with the slowest trains you must have gotten word of where I was within a few days! But it took you a whole month to get here?"

He squiggled in his chair. "...I didn't have the feels to go to London straight away… Besides! The meeting with uncle Howard gave me inspiration to write the confrontation between He-man and the Panther people in the abyss of/"

I cut him off before he went on tangent about his darn plots.

“Adam, your birthday was in March,and now it’s June! It’s… Only a few months! Why didn’t you come earlier?”

“...I *really* didn’t want to go to London…”

I shook my head.

“Alright. And now you are here. How long did you hesitate before you could go to New York?”

“Just a few days. Actually. You see, I am currently working on a chapter where they visit the underground city of Uranggkk and I figured that I could find some inspiration from/”

“Alright alright. Good good, yes yes. Thank heavens for inspiration…And you want my help.”

He blushed and looked away. “Actually… I wanted both of your help. I need to find a wife.”

Ah. Of course. Even if his book sold well, keeping the Castle walls upright deemed slightly more money than a bestseller could bring.

“All right old boy! Shouldn’t be too hard! What should she look like?”

“Hmm… I don’t know. I haven’t given the idea a thought.”

“Alright… How should she be?”

“Well… I can't say, really…”

“Okay then… Any kind of hobbies?”

“Oh. Well… dreadfully silly of me, but I haven’t the faintest.”

This is where Catra entered the conversation.

“Forgive me for interrupting, your lordship. But I can tell that this situation has brought both you and Miss Greyskull some distress. Let me ask you this question: Do you want an british girl or someone else?”

He shone up.

“Oh! An British girl! Definitely an british girl! I need to understand what she says!”

Catra nodded. “I see. In that case, even if time is short, at this very moment, Miss Greyskull is unavailable to return to England. I hope you understand.”

Adam nodded. “Oh yeah! That leech thing! You escaped the snare by the second, Dor!”

“Indeed your Lordship. However, in a few weeks, we should be able to return. Perhaps, if you concentrate on finishing your book? I suggest that we visit you on the 21 of July, you are staying at your cottage in Ramsgate?”

“Oh! Yes, that sounds splendid! Splendid! Then I will have time to finish the battle of Co/”

“YES THANK YOU, ADAM!” I very rarely raise my voice, but with my brother I make exceptions. “How about you finding yourself a nice hotel and then we can have lunch! And then I will show you New York! Let’s forget everything about women for a few days, shall we?”

He was more than glad to accommodate me. We had some smashing days in The B A before he went home. I may have doubled down on my nightly endeavors because frankly, this thing with the marriage did worry me. But, I found comfort in the fact that Catra had yet to say something about the matter, which she hadn’t. So if she believed it could be achieved, then It would!

End of part 1.

Part 2

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Part 2.

As it looked like Aunt Sharon had cooled down significantly as july passed, at the end of the very same month we returned to the old beehive. I did miss my friends, I love to see summer beaming forth across Hyde Park just as much as whoever it was that said that, but I could spare myself the beaming feeling of dread. The object of playing matchmaker always leaves a sour taste in my mouth, since it is, in my opinion, so unfairly one-sided! Very few people say "Oh how I wish I could find a girl to love!" and then they do, and then they love! Most people say "I wouldn't mind someone" And that someone has a fault of some kind that always leads to the inevitable doom.

I say, love and be loved but have reasonable expectations! A chap who highly enjoys, say modeltrains, would probably be a bit miffed should the wife drag him away from his small locomotives and, I don't know, insist for him to become a member of parliament instead! The world of model engines is much more important! Or, the other way around of course. I myself absolutely hated when Myrtle decided that riding was not suitable for a lady. Me and that poor member of parliament could have shaken hands over spouses that thought they knew best

Not to mention the fact that most people who say "I know the PERFECT woman/man/whatever for him/her (Mostly him…)" has a tendency to always start with themselves. They find someone who is a copy of them and probes them on to an unsuspecting subject. Let us take Aunt Sharon as an example. Her fifth favourite subject

is to find someone to marry uncle Howard to. “It is a shame that Howard isn’t married. The name Ordac deserves to live on!” and the house and the money should stay in the family I suppose or at least within reach from Aunt Sharon! And the women she finds are always like her. Economical, Tall, abstinencers and boring. I say, if that type is so perfect for Uncle Howard, why hasn’t she married him then?

Once we had left the New York Skyline behind us I had turned my brain inside out and back again over the matter of finding a woman that would suit Adam but I couldn’t find a single one that wouldn’t in one way or another work. He is not a partygoer, he needs to have constant opportunity to write at the same time as he needs to be on his feet travelling and he must never ever be close to a stove. The only woman who is willing to stay home most of the time, yet travel the world on a second's notice and cooks like a restaurateur I know is Catra, and he is NOT getting her.

And we had not set our foot over the threshold of the old lair until a telegram came bouncing in our faces. Adam invited us to his villa over the weekend “to discuss the possibilities and necessities”. There was also a foot note about an ‘old fashioned shy red haired girl. I shivered and showed Catra the telegram.

“So, Catra… Wedding affair.”

“Quite so, miss Greyskull.”

“I do like my brother, but he can be such a dimwit at times.”

“Indeed, miss Greyskull.”

“Unfortunately I don’t know any bachelorettes at the moment that would suit him and are available. Honoria Glossop is always at hand I suppose, but she would kill him.”

“Very true, miss Greyskull.”

“And by the way, what was that about my brother needing an english girl, Catra?”

“Well miss. I foresaw some of the difficulties finding a girl that suited Lord Greyskulls [very brief pause] personality. I imagined that if we could persuade him to wait until our return to London, it would, as they say, buy us some time, miss. Now that we are here, there will be no limitations. We can search high and low, miss.”

Shamefully I have to admit that I had my suspicions about Catras motives, but now it was all clear! Although, I don’t think a Spanish girl would suit my brother. I was swinging a beacher with the heiress of that small kingdom… Avalor? Very charming and sparkling, but maybe a bit too much for Adam. I let those thoughts go and concentrated on the now.

“Well Catra. Let’s entertain my brother and pretend to have someone for him. But where to find this ‘good ol fashioned shy red haired gal’? Do you know anyone like that?”

“No, miss Greyskull.” I bit my lip.

“Neither do I. blast it, I think they are extinct!”

“More or less, Miss. I had a cousin twice removed that had somewhat that feature.”

“And what happened to her?”

“Unfortunately she died in a fire, miss. She couldn’t bring herself to shout ‘help’ when the firemen came along and when they found her it was too late.”

I shook my head. “That kind of girl would never look at Adam. Ah well. We will find something out. Well, at least we don’t have to make any schemes this time.” To get my mind further off things I scrammed down to the princess club for some distractions.

On the way I was met with the most wonderful sight! A young lady, about my age, with her hair cut so short you could hardly do more with it than put it under a hat! I walked straight up to her and asked for the name of her hairdresser! I got it and went there straight away. It was a quick affair and the man was most accommodating. It was the perfect haircut for a young woman on the move, he said and I couldn't agree more. And the looks I got on the way to the club! I say, the mood began to rise inside me and it was with the happiest of "Ahoy"s I reentered the club's premise.

It was a most rewarding return! All eyes were on me and the amounts of "Hi Adora!s" "I say, welcome back, old egg!" and "Glad to see N.Y didn't kill you, Greyskull" propelled my good mood to the old classic Greyskull heights! And to top that off, there was Mermista, on her merry way to the boxing ring! The look she gave me told me all, here was someone with similar troubles to me and who wouldn't mind a few hooks and cuts to get her mind off things! Now, not that I was in a dry need for a pick me up, as I just said, but let it never be known to the world that I will abandon a sister in need! She greeted me just like I expected, good old Mermista, always to be trusted. "Greyskull. What in the world died on your head?"

"I think it's perfect! Airy!"

"Aireness is not something your head needs more of, Greyskull."

I just smiled, her jabs felt like honey on the old homesick mind! Ah, it was good to be back!

Five rounds later where I have to say, she did take me down, we sat down next to a plate filled to the brim with oceanic delicacies and two large containers of the finest red wine. Now, I know, people say never red wine to fish, but that is just for amateurs and people who don't know Mermista. Or Glimmer, by the way.

We made a short affair of the scallops and the grilled salmon before anyone of us broke the silence. As always, boxing gives you a certain appetite! But the wrinkle on Mermistas forehead didn't go away and over the coffee and the cigarillos, I went right on the bulls eye!

"Mermista. I deduce you have troubles."

"Go rot, Greyskull."

"Now, It can't be about business, because you are not wearing black."

"I wish you were electric, then I could shut you off. Damn it, I wish most people were electric!"

"And it's not family related, because you have not left the country."

"WAITER! A WHISKEY! DOUBLE!"

"And it's not Sea-hawk because the times have been silent about arsons. So, what is it? The dentist?"

She blinked. "Greyskull, the moments where you briefly show that you actually have the ability to think is even more scary than your usual demeanor."

"Don't change the subject!"

"...It's… A woman."

"Ah!" And after a second. "eh?" Mermista has never shown any signs of being interested in the fair sex, but to be honest, everyone was surprised when she married Sea-Hawk as well so… I suppose never say never is true.

"NO, I have not fallen in love. …Sea-hawk is bad enough, I don't need another fool in my life…"

“Tell me all then!”

She gave me a peculiar look. “You know what, I will! You of all people should be able to relate. I need to find a prospect for a husband for someone.”

It is interesting how fast a good mood can disappear! But I didn’t want to show Mermista my distress, instead I gave the secret sign to George V that meant “the strongest you have in the biggest glass” and leaned forward.

“It’s… Sea-Hawks cousin. Teela.”

“I had no idea he had a cousin.”

“Most of his family are ashamed of him, but Teela had no choice but to talk to him. You know his father is an admiral?”

I have to say I was surprised. I had always believed that Mermista married a commoner, not a soldier!

“No… No, I didn’t know that.”

“Alright, now you do. He is, and so is his brother. His brother is the better of them. Admiral Duncan Saltire. And Teela is his daughter. She would have been a perfect naval officer.”

“Hadn’t she been a woman.”

“Yes. Some parts of the suffragette movement I stand behind completely. If Isombard had been but a quarter of the man she is, his career would have been improachable and I would have been the respectable wife of an officer.”

“Mermista, you don't really mean that.”

“I do mean that. Doesn’t mean I would have preferred it.”

Ha. I have always known that Mermista prefers the Chaos Sea-Hawk brings.

“So, when you said his uncle was the better officer…”

“You know that Sea-Hawks yacht is named ‘Sea-dragon VI right?”

“Yes?”

“Wanna guess who was in charge of Sea-Dragon I-IV?”

“Ah.”

“Yep. Arson runs in the family. But Uncle Duncan married a stable Irish woman so Teela has good genes and red hair.”

“But why would you need to help her?”

“...She says that since I had found the perfect husband, good looking, stupid as they come, and meek, I should have the nose for finding one since She wants one of the same kind.”

She paused. “Stupid cow… Sea-Hawk isn’t stupid…”

I have always found it interesting that Mista can be so loyal in the same breath as she calls her husband a damn snail.

“And since it’s Uncle Duncans daughter, I more or less have to help her. The ones in the family with braincells needs good soil to grow.”

“Well, let’s drink to that!” I said as my cure for dread had arrived. “But I hope you don’t have to find one tomorrow.”

“Well, if you ask her, yesterday would have been best! But nah. She turns twentyone on August the 26th. I have at least a month. Hey, Greyskull! Perhaps you want to meet her? She is coming to the club to hear my latest progress and we could use a distraction.”

“From what?”

“The fact that I have made no progress. She is cool, but fierce!”

And she was. She arrived at the club about twenty minutes later. The first thing that struck me was "red." Her hair was of that color you usually see on the young lead at a melodramatic play in a country theater in Surrey, that says "Mum" and "Trouble and strife". The second was "Orange." I have no idea who convinced her that she was suited for an orange dress, but I could feel Catra having a seizure in my mind as I looked at her. The third thing was "tall". I rarely get to look someone straight in the eyes without bending, but she was the same height as me, if not even taller. She offered me her hand, her grip was as hard as mine, and she greeted me in a pleasant but loud voice. "TEELA SALTIRE. AND WHO DE DEVIL ARE YOU?" The irish accent was not as thick as I expected, but it was prominent. I assumed that Lady Saltire was a woman who could move mountains, or rather, one who was a mountain and refused to do the same.

"Adora Greyskull. I am a friend of Mermistas."

"Oh really? Could 'ave fooled me! Well, is there anyone who can get a gal a drink somewhere 'round 'ere?" The shy one was at her side ready to take an order. Of course she wanted a Guinness, but luckily the princess club serves the real thing. One of the founders was a Lady O'Hara.

"Let me tell you, lady! You would think dat in town like London you would find a husband as easy as you would find a tube station but I 'ave been 'ere for a week and they don't even dare to talk to me! Dat's why I turned to Good old MErmista for help. You know 'ow she managed to tie my cousin down? Yeah, she knows!"

I have to say that hadn't it been for the fact that her conversation returned to the object of finding a husband every other minute or so, Teela was overall a nice acquaintance. She was not a keen boxer, but an avid fencer and I instantly booked a date next week for a match! She was an avid epéer, just like myself and I did manage to keep the conversation flowing for several minutes on the subject of whether the Belgian Grip was to be preferred over the hungarian. But then it was back to husbands…

“Say, Greyskull!” (We did drop titles in the moment the subject of Rugby came up) you look like a fit woman! You don’t happen to know any good men?”

I did freeze a little but Mermista said “Nah, don’t bother to ask Adora. She is and will always be the noble bachelorette. Besides, when you have a valet like Catra, there is no need for a husband.”

To my great relief she nodded. “I sure wouldn’t mind staying a spinster, but you know how it is. Relatives that keeps on about ‘good for you’ and ‘the family must prosper’. A load of baloney if you ask me, but I do love my old man and I would ‘ate to see him sad. So I just have to find de one who suits me best! Nice talking to you. Greyskull! Should you find someone, give me a call! Until next week!”

And then I left for home. I was in a state of very mixed feelings but I did at least find it a relief not to have two people to match up someone with.

As I returned home to the lair I found Catra not greeting me but staring at me.

“What ho, Catra?”

“...I… Miss… “ She swallowed. Hard. Three times. Blimey! She must be really upset! “Miss Greyskull. I must say I had no idea you had been involved in an assault.”

“...Assault? Why would I be?”

“...Well… Your hair… miss.”

Ah. In an instant, it was all clear. Of course Catra wouldn’t approve of my new haircut. I say, that woman is as conservative as Mr Churchill!

“I haven’t been assaulted. I have visited a barber.”

“...One who must have been more than mildly intoxicated then.”

“Catra, I like my hair.”

“So did I,miss Greyskull. So DID I”.

“Look here, Catra. My hair and my head is my own to do whatever I want with. I will keep it like this for as long as I wish and I forbid you to make any further comments about it. Is that clear?”

She straightened her back. “Yes Miss Greyskull. As you wish.”

“Thank you.”

“With your permission, I will start with dinner. If that is not against your wishes?”

“Why would that be?”

“Considering you are the woman of the household, I should ask for your permission in the future, miss greyskull.”

Ah. So that was how she was going to play it. Well, I suppose the haircut put some emphasis on my eyes and gave me a slight cruel composure but really! A haircut doesn’t change someone's personality! Really!

“Catra! You are free to do whatever you wish in the household!”

She coughed discreetly. “You only minutes ago forbade me to speak about your haircut again. I can only assume you want a more direct approach to everything from now on.”

“CATRA! NOW…”

but she had de-materialzed. I sighed, and this day that had begun so well!

Ah well, she would come around. She always did. I sank down on the sofa, deciding to look over the opportunities I had. I had to talk to Adam first of course, but it wouldn’t hurt to actually look over my own circles. So, who was free and willing? Perfuma was

free, but not willing. Frosta was free AND willing, but she needed a few more years of polish and experience. She was, on the plus side, an avid comic book-reader, as was my brother, but I can't really see a good relationship start with a bonding over Buck Rogers. Not to mention that her love of skiing is in direct opposition to Adam. He is a beach man through and through.

Lady Netossa was not married but… At times, I had the distinct feeling that she and her companion Lady Spinneralla was in similar circumstances to me and Catra, and besides, she was well over 40. And Adam was much but not a gold-digger. There was Dora Mason… She loved exploring the world on paper but I had a feeling she was a bit too childish. You shouldn't be talking to your maps. Lady Florence Gray was definitely willing, but considering she had been one of DTs old conquests, she might be a little too willing… And I needed someone who could at least see my brother as he was.

The situation looked rather dark, but as long as I had Catra with me, I figured there wouldn't be any troubles.

"Yes. It will all work out well in the end, and if it hasn't, it just means we haven't reached the end yet!"

The second I had spoken those words, the telephone rang. Catra answered and the shadow of a face in grave lust of throwing up moved over her face.

"Miss Greyskulls residence. Ah. Hello Mrs Weaver. Yes Mrs Weaver. I will bring her to the telephone." She gave me a look. "Mrs Shadow Weaver wish to talk to you, miss Greyskull. If it's not much of an endeavour to you, I will bring the phone to you."

I just nodded. The next moment I had Aunt Sharon in my ears.

"Adora. So you dare to come crawling back like the worm you are."

"Hullo Aunt Sharon! How are you today!?"

“Spare me your imbecilities. I would have had you thrown away with the garbage if anything in this world would be considered fair. But unfortunately I need you to do something for me. I take it that you have heard that your brother is on the prospect of finding someone to marry?”

“Oh. Oh yes.”

I steeled myself, waiting for the inevitable. ‘Find someone suiting’, ‘make sure it’s not below his station’, ‘just help the man!’.

But what she actually said made me turn to stone in an instant.

“It is of the most importance that your brother doesn’t marry. And It will be your obligation to make sure he won’t!”

End of part 2

Chapter End Notes

Dun dun DUUUUUUH!

Part 3

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Part 3.

I am not, dare I to say, the chap that gets silenced easily. I mean, I have seen my share of nasty things over the years. Like the pearl onion and jam incident at the princess club or the time that Lady Bottingham made a bet that she could drink two liters of milk and sit through a whole board meeting. But this made me go all "...!"

And the first thing I managed to stutter out was "what ho?"

"Adora, don't make me put 'deafness' on your seemingly endless list of faults. You heard me well enough. I need you to put an end to this nonsense about your brother getting married."

"But…but…" I swallowed and managed to regain control of my voice. "So, he has found someone then?"

"I highly doubt that. The man is your brother, and I don't trust him to sit the proper way at a better lavatory."

"Aunt Sharon!"

"Oh please, stop being such a prude. We all go there. This marriage must be stopped at all costs."

"B-but…"

"Adora. Either think before you speak, or don't speak at all. And knowing you, the silence will be a nice change."

I did my best to form a sentence but my inside was filled with all sorts of conflicting feelings and emotions but finally I managed to stutter out, “B-but you wanted me to get married?”

“YES I did, Adora. And how did you repay me for my efforts? If you don’t want me to mention that mess again you do as I say.”

“Oh. Oh yes! My lips are sealed.”

“No. You are still talking.”

“Oh. Oh. Um… Aunt Sharon! I don’t follow! You worked so hard with… EHrm…Why don’t you want my brother to marry?”

“That is none of your concern.”

“Look here, Aunt Sh/”

“Adora. Listen and listen good. You will make sure that Adam Greyskull doesn't marry or I will drag you to church, grab the first slob I can see on the street, have you married and sent on a boat to Brazil within two hours. Have I made my point clear?”

I swallowed. “Yes Aunt Sharon.”

“Good. His birthday is on the 26th of september. If I receive an invitation to any date before that… Get used to the smell of oil and sweat, Adora.”

I swallowed. “Yes, Aunt Sharon.”

“Good. Have a nice day.”

And with that, the call ended. I am not sure if dread is a word you can bend like that, but this was dreader than any dread I have ever dreaded. There was only one thing to do!

“Catra!”

She floated in and rested in the corner. The cold look in her eye had not gone away but I hoped that faced with the situation, she

would fall back and help me!

“You called, Miss Greyskull?”

“Catra! This is a mess!”

“Yes, it is, miss. But there are, I have learned, stores that sell extensions. Even if it…”

“Catra! To hell with my hair!”

“If you ask me, that is where it is right now, miss.”

“Catra! For jobs sake, this is worse than my hair! Aunt Sharon called!”

“Yes miss. If you remember, I was the one who answered the phone.”

“Catra… She wants me to stop the marriage!”

“...Excuse my bewilderment, miss Greyskull, but I have yet to learn about a marriage? I admit I am not aware of every romantic moment in London at the moment but I know your circles rather well, if I may say, miss. And I haven’t heard about one.”

“And you never will, should Aunt Sharon get her will! She wants me to stop Adam from marrying!”

She nodded. “I see, miss Greyskull.”

“You ‘see’? I say, Catra!”

“Miss Greyskull, if you permit me to say this, given that this task comes from someone living in the seventh circle, considering the energy his Lordship has spent on the matter up until now, if this goes on he won’t succeed in marrying anyone within the next decade.”

“But you don’t get it, Catra! I have, WE have already promised him to help! And what if he finds someone? I mean… Stranger

things have happened!”

They sure have! Uncle Crosby, who was said in his youth to be akin to a Greek god, had a strange interest in the subject of playing the accordion, which he did quite well and with passion. It was also said that once he would get married, he would either do it for money or for the sake of family but one day he returned from a trip to germany with a middle aged woman who was ‘ugly in that way where you couldn’t really say what it was save for the fact that you felt repulsion’ but she shared Uncle Crosby's love for the accordion and they got married two months later. They must have been an odd sight, as he was 6’1, she around 4’7 and with a slight lameness, but she gave him three sons and apparently they were annoyingly happy, according to Aunt Sharon.

“Aunt Sharon will marry me off with some random slob from the street and ferry me off to Brazil!”

“I see, miss Greyskull.”

I was starting to get angry. “You ‘see’? I have explained to you everything about this situation, that it is not only a pickle but a whole jar!? And yet, you still just ‘see’?”

The cold look unfroze a few degrees when she answered.

“I see that you are in great distress, Miss Greyskull. However, at this very moment, there is very little to be done. There is no lady in his lordship's life yet, and up until then, there is not much to do. To be honest, if you just decide not to help him, that would probably do as much good as anything else.”

“Yes, but *you* promised to help him as well.”

She coughed discreetly. “I will not go and visit him against your wish, Miss Greyskull.”

“That doesn’t help! We are going to visit him this weekend!”

“You could cancel, miss.”

“I would never! A Greyskull is true to her words! Catra, there has to be another way out of this!”

“I am afraid at this very moment I don’t see one, miss. If that was all…”

I glared at her, quite…. unnatural, I must say. And then I added “No, it was not all. I need a drink.”

“Very good, miss.”

And she left to make me that drink. After I got it, I was alone with my thoughts. Catra was right of course. I could just not do anything and watch my brother go right into Aunt Sharons trap headfirst. But he WAS my baby brother (25 minutes!) and I have always felt a slight responsibility for him. I couldn’t just leave him, I had given him my word! And I had promised him Catra’s help! I looked at myself in the mirror. I looked sharp. Really, there was no logical reason for Catras coldness. Why in the world couldn’t she approve of my haircut. Damn that woman! It was here to stay, and I was the one in charge! I paid for her bed and… well, she made mine and slept in it… but that was beside the point! If there only was a way that I could do both things…

I went to bed early to have a good night's sleep and hopefully a fresh start tomorrow.

Unfortunately I didn’t, I had a terrible dream of being married to a tall, dirty man with a huge black beard named “John” who insisted on me cooking him meat pies and who said “shut the pie-hole, you B-d wench” every time I tried to talk to him.

And Catra entering with the traditional H, E and T didn’t approve of my mood, but at least I wasn’t hungry anymore. Today was Wednesday and on Sunday we were going to Ramsgate. I decided that since Catra showed no signs to help me and while the danger was great, it wasn’t like I was looking at an oncoming train chained to the rails. It was more like sitting on a bench next to a

cafe watching a cab driver having his tea break, knowing that maybe one day he would run me over. Possibly. And at the moment, the lad had his third refill and second sandwich so, I couldn’t really describe my situation as being even the sligtest in a jiffy.

So I followed my usual timetable. Boxing with Huntara today(She had a really mean left hook but I managed to reach a draw which I consider a win. I am also quite sure that the match being arranged now was the work of Catra. She can be so petty.), Tennis with Lord Little-Gore on Friday (Also a bit unusual, but not the work of Catra. I have been in the old man's good favour for some time and Anatole's Bavete et moules au safran and his Choucroute au saumon et crème à l'aneth didn’t disappoint me!

And on Sunday we were going to my brother.

This was Saturday, and I had no real idea what to do. With Catra being as she is, I had started to have lunch in the city. She would never dishonor dinner, but lunch had a tendency to be cold when she was angry and oxtongue you only have once in that state. Again, I spotted Mermista and Teela. I waved them over and they happily sat down. I got the feeling that Mermista felt Teela ‘talking too much’ and she couldn’t actually ask her to shut it. The difference between friends and aquantances. I, for one, gladly took the opportunity to have a chat with the lady. In fact, I offered to have a spontaneous match of fencing this very day, if she didn’t mind. She didn’t and once we had gobbled down lunch, we got suited up. Mermista joined. She is not interested, but she enjoys watching me ‘get my lower regions handed to me’. Well, not exactly that word… but that region! We had a much enjoyable spar, and it struck me how much I enjoyed the presence of this lady. And I also realized how little Glimmer would. Glimmer prefers to be the one doing the majority of talking, and Teela is not the one to be silent just because etiquette demands it. And her parade is impeccable! Just to make sure that Catra would behave and not start to mess up dinner as well, I invited them

both to my abode. As we entered, I was quite convinced that Catra had plans for a green pea soup for dinner, which she knows I absolutely hate, and there are very few dishes I truly despise, but in the presence of Mrs Anastassakis and Miss Saltire she could hardly serve anything akin to those. There was a bowl of peas on the table, which I knew to be a threat, but the coq au vin she served was splendid.

I couldn't say for sure, but I got the wild hunch that Catra did not sport a very favourable opinion about Teela.

I can't put my finger on it exactly, but the look she gave as Teela said "No disrespect, Greyskull, but I find de sports where you 'ave a real chance to bash someones 'ead in as more in me line. Nothing wrong wit Rugby but dere's no real risk, aight?" was rather telling.

As they left, I asked Catra what her opinion was about Teela. I got a feeling that she struggled between being cold to me and the wild wish to tell me exactly what her thoughts were on the woman in question. Finally she said "She… Is a very composite person, Miss Greyskull." And then she turned and left the room. But that was enough. I now knew that Catra did not approve of her, at least not completely.

Sunday saw us on the Victoria Station embanking a first class carriage to Ramsgate. I do love the old car but sometimes it's nice to have more than five glasses of wine for dinner. Catra carried my bag and looked as always the perfect gentlewomans gentlewoman, but she made no conversation, and I was happy that I had the latest Christie at hand.

Dinner was a very familiar affair, just me and Adam at a rather un-lordy small table. Father would never have settled for less than twenty feet, but that's Adam for you. We had a quite delicious,

albeit slightly off meal. Adams valet Orko is a… rather peculiar type of person. He has been with Adam since boarding school, when he saved him from drowning. I think it was Adam that was saved but I am not completely sure… Orko is not a good valet, in that that he more or less always manages to do the opposite of what he has planned, but Adam is so fond of him that he can't let him go. And as long as he doesn't mess up Adams scripts…We had Eggs a la maison, (which meant 'however they ended up in the pan served with a salad and croutons'), a very salty, but still quite deliciously crispy duck breast and a kind of german cake, Schwartzwälder Kirschtarte, for dessert. (Orko is german. Or Danish. Or I don't know.) The man has one ability that I know Catra is jealous of. It looks almost like the man doesn't walk. He floats in and out of a room, completely silent, as if his feet don't even touch the ground. He is not a part of Catras club but for some reason I am convinced that he knows Scorpia…

The slight strange but tasty meal put behind us and inside of us (And the delicious fried potatoes and green pepper sauce told me that Catra had made her way to the kitchen and refused to leave) sharing a cigar and a glass of rum, we spoke about the wedlock issue only twice. (The rest of the time we talked about Cricket. And I managed to steer him away from describing his plots thrice. My word…) At one time I made a remark of the slight unusual dessert, and Adam replied "You know Adora. I would like something that was exactly the opposite of that cake."

"Huh? Isn't a cake very much not a human?"

"Yes yes, but I am using a metaphor!"

Ah. Of course, a writer being all fancy! "Blimey!"

"Yes. Well, as delicious as this is, it's all so very complicated. Once the cake is done, but before you can decorate it with cream, you have to drench it in a very particular cherry wine. And you have to have just the right amount, not to make that taste take over completely. And then you have to use the right kind of chocolate for the garnish to go well with the cherries and/"

“Adam, I think you lost yourself in the metaphor.”

“Oh. Darn it, I did! Perhaps I could use it for the banquet scene in/”

“Adam!”

“Oh. Yes. Anyway. I want someone… simple. Someone… Homely. Quiet. Intellectual. Someone who doesn't mind a family and the simple quiet life in the countryside.”

I could have sworn that I felt Catras presence in that moment but when I turned around the door was empty and all that was left was a slight cold chill down my neck. Adam hadn’t noticed anything, he just continued with a dreamy voice, “And she must have red hair.” I was a bit out of myself and could only reply, “Well, go to Dublin then. Or Glasgow, or Edinburgh."

“I would, but I don’t have that much time.”

“Ah.”

There was not much more to add after that, and we concentrated on the cake.

But as we sat down with our brandy and cigars, I realized the solution to all of my problems. It came to me after a few whiffs of the very excellent Spanish cigar that Adam had purchased last year, and it came to me with a flow of red hair… I would seemingly help Adam, at the same time as I did what Aunt Sharon wanted, and I would show Catra who was the lady of the household and that she’d better get used to it! I actually had the perfect candidate that would satisfy both needs.

“Well, Adam, “I said, “With everything you have mentioned to me, I think I can safely say that all your worries will be gone. I know exactly the right woman for you.”

“Oh!” He paused. “really?”

“Yes really! Adam, what ho?”

“Well… Adora… To be frank, when I asked for help, It was more that I hoped for Catra to… you know…”

“Ah, but brother! Do not worry! Catra knows everything and she has not a bad word to say about her!” Technically that was true. “Composite” was not bad unless you knew Catra. He was not completely convinced, but leaned back.

“All right then. Where can I meet her?”

“Come and visit London next Saturday, and I will introduce you to her. Her name is Teela Saltire.”

It is very unbecoming of a Greyskull, but on the inside I couldn’t help sniggering at my own cunningness.

End of part 3

Chapter End Notes

> In case you are wondering,THIS is how Adoras new haircut looks like.
> Well, minus the cruel face and the sword, but you get the idea.

Part 4

Part 4

On the return train to London I told Catra everything about my plan. And that I may have sauted myself a bit in the praise and gratitude Adam gave me. She informed me that I used the wrong term. Ha. Like I shouldn't know my french cousine. As always, I expected a "hmmm" but all I got was a nod and a "very well, miss Greyskull."

"Catra" I said. "You don't approve of my plan."

"It would be too far from my station to give my opinion about that kind of personal matters, Miss Greyskull."

Oh, so that was it, was it? A colder than cold shoulder? Even when I… I mean, I found absolutely no holes in my plan, but let us be honest, Catra never approves of my plans, says I forgot to take this or that into the picture. Oh, I know all too well that she prefers to be the painter herself but now she couldn't even bring herself to mock me? Well, well then Catra! The game was afoot! I was going to show her that it took a Greyskull to understand a Greyskull and that she would have to come crawling back to me, head down in apology, before I would even consider asking her for advice again! And damn it, she would be the one to cut my hair short next time!

I have always wondered about that expression, 'far from my station'. If it was Charing Cross I would believe them, no one lives there, but there are plenty of people around Victoria or Euston, for example. As the trip rolled on, I had finished my book (And again, mrs Christie baffled me! I would never have expected it to be the husband!) and refreshed myself with a cup of tea (and another round of attention from the crowd about my hair. If Catra had only seen…) I felt in a much better mood. Perhaps it was a bit

too harsh to force Catra to cut my hair. Honestly I am not sure she has that ability, but it wouldn't surprise me in the least. She has served for quite a few mistresses and masters before me and at least one of them should have asked, at least for a trim!

Anyway, as we rolled back into Victoria station and hauled a cab to reach the old lair for a quick bite before bed, I decided that she could keep her mood. I was not going to stop being my old generous Greyskull-self just because we had a bit of a … miscommunication.

"I say, Catra. It has been a lovely day in the countryside."

"Yes, Miss Greyskull."

"The fresh air, the wind from the sea… The endless meadows…"

"Quite so, Miss Greyskull. Although if you permit my remark, there aren't many meadows around Ramsgate. It's a quite typical English farming and fishing community."

"Oh. Ah well, the endless acres then! The backbone of British agriculture, the seed that grows into a… What's it called?"

"A spike, miss Greyskull."

"Spike? Damn word for something you end up eating."

"Indeed, miss Greyskull."

"Makes you wonder if that was indeed the intention from the beginning, Catra."

"It makes one wonder indeed, miss Greyskull."

"And one has to wonder how that bloke was constructed, who first got the idea to grind it to flour! What did they do before that, boil it and eat it as it was?"

“There are a few cultures around the world that do exactly that, miss Greyskull.”

“Blimey! Have they never been introduced to sandwiches? Speaking of that, I do feel a bit peckish. Could you perhaps…”

“As you wish, miss Greyskull.”

As we crossed the threshold, Catra swept for the kitchen and I took the sofa.

Overall it had been a good weekend, and when Catra entered with two bacon sandwiches and a cold beer things just ended on top. This was going to be a good week.

Two days later it was still a good week. Well, I hadn’t actually been in touch with Adam since we had left, but I was sure that he hadn’t gotten cold feet. Also, the free-lifting session on Monday went without a hitch.

On Tuesday I had an extra riding session with Swiftwind (since I had to spend the weekend horseless. It was a necessary sacrifice but damn if I could meet his reproachful eyes at the stables without a tear and a hearty excuse. but he forgave me, like the splendid Johnny he is!).

Wednesday however, I saw, or rather I heard, a telephone call from Aunt Sharon.

“Adora. I hear nothing about whether the situation concerning your brother is promising or going down the gutter.

“Do not worry, Aunt Sharon! I have the situation under perfect control.”

“As always I fear the worst when you are being enthusiastic, Adora. Perhaps I should send mr. Nightfire over as well…”

“No no! That won’t be at all necessary! I will scare him from marriage for many years! My brother that is!”

“...Yes, I think you actually could do that. Well then, Adora. Best wishes.”

Even if she was rather out of charachterly positive, it still gave me the creeps and I had to nag Mermista into a small boxing match to feel better. My first impulse was to call Teela for a fencing game… but all of a sudden there was a thought in my mind about Esau and Jacob there that I didn’t like… We were still on for Thursday, but I couldn’t bring myself to look at that poor girl more than that. But, even if it is somewhat akin to the vipers bite, a Greyskull stands by her word! And his, should that be the case. So in the evening I telephoned my brother.

“What ho, Adam?”

“Splendid! I managed to edit two chapters and finish a third!”

“Yes yes, jolly good old chap and all that, but what about Teela?”

“Oh… Oh yes. Miss Saltire.”

“Adam, you are not getting cold feet, are you? Catra will make her best Filet mignon and you don’t want to miss that!”

“I … am prepared to see you, Adora. But I am not sure… What kind of woman is she?”

“Ah, exactly your type!”

“Are you sure about that, Adora?”

“Oh yes! She has the most smashing red hair, the softest of lips and the starriest of eyes.”

“And you know about the lips how?”

“...Ehm…A girl knows those things old chap, he he.”

"...Alright, I guess you do. But Adora, what is she like?"

"She is… par for the course, habitual, wonted… She is not of many interests, she prefers to do one thing at the time." At least parts of that were true.

"Okay. If you say so, then I trust you." He added as an afterthought "she's not loud, is she?"

"Oh! Oh no, not at all!" She does talk quite a lot and she is very forward, but I wouldn't say she's loud! …Not compared to some of my fellow members at least.

On Thursday however I had to steel myself, trying to be normal around Teela,and she almost beat me! I say, I wonder how those double agents and traitors do this kind of thing! I can barely fool my not-sister-in-law without loosing a match of fencing! On Friday I decided I needed another day with Swift Wind, I just couldn't take the silence in the old lair anymore! I even spent the afternoon with Perfuma to do something else.

I got to say, her relationship with Scorpia is bordering on 'way too friendly'. Not that I mind, Scorpia is if nothing,warm, charming and kind but really, you don't allow your maid to sit down and have tea with you, do you? And especially not in a dark blue dress! It was very suitable for her of course! But still.

At least it took some of the issue off my mind and when I arrived home quite late at night I didn't mind that Catra had gone to bed in her own room. Tomorrow this would be all over.

After breakfast and a quick shower I was ready for my guests. Adam arrived first, and we sat down and had an amiable chat about everything and nothing when the doorbell rang. Catra entered the room shortly after. "Miss Saltire, your Lordship, miss Greyskull.

"Ah! So you are de lad dat Adora thinks is good enough for me. Well, let's see if you 'ave what it takes! What do you think 'bout rock climbing?"

Adam looked not only scared but aghast! This was going to go well. And there was a certain satisfaction in seeing how I probably looked like when Leech was introduced. Or when Bow proposed to Perfuma. Drat it all, perhaps I should become a villain instead? It had indeed a certain feeling. But as dinner continued in the same manner, I must admit I had trouble stomaching it all. It was quite fuzzly, if you know what I mean. Not totally uncomfortable but almost! Teela spoke and Adam answered in short sentences.

“So, I hear that de alps are nice dis time of year.”

“Ah. Um. Yes. Interesting.”

“There is no feeling as really exhausting yourself with physical activities, don’t you agree?”

“Oh of course, of course.”

“There must be excellent walks along the coast where you live?”

“Possibly, possibly.”

And so on.

The food was excellent of course, Catra is maybe not up there with Anatole, but occasionally she is reaching for the rim of his uniform!

In between dessert and coffee he dragged me aside. “Adora, I don’t think this is a good idea. She is not exactly like you said she would be.” I had a feeling that he would get straight to the point and I had tried to build up my nerves to face him. I had to imagine Aunt Sharon's face without glasses to not bail on it all.

I had no support from Catra, save for the food. Damn the woman! I even tried to use some pomada to make my hair look really slick but that only led to her crushing the bottle ‘by accident’ she claimed. Ha.

“Adam, she is just.. nervous! Yes! Nervous!”

“Nervous.” He didn’t sound convinced.

“But of course old chap! Imagine it yourself! Here we are, two siblings, two well to do-londoners against her, a single lonely woman! She wants to make a really good impression and wants to show her spirit! It will pass, I assure you.”

“But Adora, she/” I cut him off.

“Adam. Teela may look like she is nothing but a mouth with red hair, but trust me. Catra approves of her and you know what it means when Catra approves of someone.”

He shook his head slowly. “I don’t know if I will trust Catras' judgement from now on…” I felt that I was losing ground and now I had to imagine Aunt Sharon without the veil (I don’t really know how she looks without it so you can imagine what I could imagine! It did the trick though… But I had trouble sleeping afterwards.) to come up with something to say. It took a few blinks but then I had it.

“Ah. Well… But you see… Addie old lad… Yes! Addie! But you have only seen her in London! And you hate London and your nerves are on their toes! Addie, bring her to Ramsgate! In your quiet, slow little abode, she will see the real you and you will appreciate the real her!”

It all came out of me so well! And I am known to be a terrible liar! Ha. Greyskull - Catra, 1-0!

I could hardly bring myself to be alone with them so I called Glimmer to see if there was an outing of some sort. Luckily for me, there was. (There always is, when Glimmer is around.) It took a bit of convincing from my side (Adam, you need to show your good and knightley side. This might be the woman from your dreams!”) to make him accept the idea of a wing-ding.

Now, any evening with Glimmer and Bow is always a joy, and it was nice to see the newlyweds again! Well, not that I haven’t seen them after the wedding, but that doesn’t stop it from being

nice, does it? And it was indeed again, the months in the new country had been significantly Glimmer-free. So I had but waited for a moment to rejoin with the old eggs! To my slight surprise (but to be honest, actual delight) Teela and Glimmer fut like a glove! They more or less owned the floor, and to be honest, Glimmer's dancing can have that effect on her surroundings. Still, if you watch from a safe distance, it is quite enjoyable. However, it did hurt a bit so see Adam so miserable. He hates loud music and lots of people. He looked so off that even Bow came up to me.

"Is there something wrong with Adam? He looks like… well… Glimmer, when she can't have pancakes."

Oh, that bad? I managed to smile and gave him a reassuring pat on the back.

"Ah, he is just not a London soul. But I will tell you a secret, I am trying to match him and young Teela up. I think it is important for a young couple to see all aspects of their possible spouses before the ring goes on, don't you?" Bow shot Adam a glance.

"If that is what she will see, I don't expect any rings on soon."

It was true. Adam had not danced once, while Teela and Glimmer had dominated the floor.

"Ah, but the night is young and he is just waiting for the right moment to show her his signature step!"

"Isn't that falling over?"

It is. Adam is a terrible dancer. But I had to keep it up for all of us. Damn it, lying is harder than they say! In the end I offered Bow a drink and reluctantly he agreed. We Toodle-ooed early, since I actually did have a polo game that Sunday but Teela asked Adam for a walk along the Thames.

I heard that he had left for Ramsgate the next morning, and I was more than a little terrified that he would indeed break it off. But as I rang Teela up the next day to arrange for our net fencing, I was

informed that she was out. She was visiting a young gentleman some miles outside london.’ Ha! It worked! …Or did it? Was I trying to get them together or not?

But I wasn’t too worried. This was all just Adam being a gentleman. By next week, Teela would be back here, maybe in a few tears but overall safe and sound. And Adam would be unmarried still.

I couldn’t help feeling somewhat of a sting in my chest but the polo-game made me feel a bit better.

The following week was slow. I heard no News from Adam, which was neither good nor bad, and I heard nothing from Teela either. But I decided to let nature run its course. Teela would tire Adam out in days, the look from the joint told me all, even if it hurt.

Mermista was over to France for business, making the week alarmingly boxing-less, and the rugby game had been canceled due to bad weather. That left me with nothing to lift my spirits save for riding and last polo-match, while it had seen us delivering a crushing victory, it also gave Swift Wind a cold. I did go out there on Tuesday, if nothing else, to give the old boy some love and Carrots, and give him some good owner/horse quality time. And grooming. But it wasn’t not really the same to spend time next to him as on him, if you understand me right.

Catra at least spoke to me in a more normal way than last week. Not that it was an improvement. Once when I asked her for a drink, she was busy mopping the floor. And the whole conversation she addressed the mop.

When I said "Catra! I am over here!" She managed to look baffled.

"My apologies, miss Greyskull. The two of you look so similar."

"Catra! That was really unnecessary! And rude."

"Yes, Miss Greyskull. It was. Would you care for a brandy or a cocktail?"

"A brandy. And please don't give it to the mop."

"I assure you, miss Greyskull, I will not. I just have to look for a mouth to separate you!"

"Catra!"

But she was out.

When Glimmer called on Thursday, inviting me to dinner, I accepted without a single hesitance! Even if said dinner included Lady Entrapta. But even her erratic conversation was like fresh air in a sauna. A bit unwelcome, yet it wakes you up.

She apparently dabbles in all kinds of sciency things.

"Right now I am in the middle of a paper on human interaction! It is so FASCINATING!"

That is a word she uses a lot. I must have made a face because she clarified herself. "The way people talk and act when they are together, either of their own will or for other reasons." Oh.

"Blimey. I wouldn’t think just looking at people talking would be much of a joy, would it? Well, not unless you are of the variety and you're supposed to laugh after every other sentence, that is!"

"A-ha! But that is just it! There is so much to learn in how people use words, what words and how they pronounciate them! For instance, You Adora, have no trouble using long elaborate sentences when you feel safe and sound but when you feel threatened or out of your comfort zone, you usually end up with things like "I say!".

"I say!" I said.

"Bow, being the moderator in every situation always uses words that are meant to sooth and loll, while Glimmer, who is naturally ag/"

"More wine, anyone?" Bow interrupted.

After that, the subject switched. We started to talk about wine but ended up in a chemistry lesson on the process of winemaking.

"I have written a monograph on the subject! It is one of the most delicate chemistry there is! Just a slight temperature change, for instance, could change the alcohol percentage with a significant number!"

"I say!"

She gave me a glance. "Hmm. Interesting… a non committal, yet enthusiastic expression that could mean anything from interest to confusion… I need to…" and she reached into her hair to pick out a small notebook in which she scribbled some. "And the others are non-plussed… meaning this is a recurring occurrence… I need to make another sub-level to this…"

"Entrapta?"

"Glimmer?"

"Sorry?"

"Oh, I just assumed we were calling out our names. Or… Oh, you wanted to bring my attention to the fact that I had broken off the conversation in a non-confrontational way since you felt attacked by my previous statement! Interesting… Let me… There!" She closed the book and put it back. "Now, wine!"

"Yes?"

"Wine?"

"I'm sorry?"

“Bow. Can. I . Have. Some. More. Wine? Please?”

And so on. I excused myself after the dessert. I didn’t want her to write a monograph over me, but the chemistry of winemaking (which she spent most of the cheesecake to lecture over) was rather interesting. Albeit so detailed that I couldn’t follow her beyond “making wine is chemistry”. I do wonder if uncle Howard can get this passionate? Probably not.

It all happened on the morning of Friday. I had barely finished my breakfast when Catra informed me that someone wanted me on the telephone.

“Mrs Weaver, miss.”

I had just managed to get my dressing-gown on as I rushed outside. Hearing from Aunt Sharon before lunch was bad enough, I didn’t want to talk to her in the state of a new-born!

“Aunt Sharon! What gives me the/” she cut me off, her voice was cold and hot at the same time.

"Adora. I just received a proclamation of the engagement between Lord Greyskull and Miss Teela Saltire. You have one week. One week, and then I will book Winchester Cathedral for the whole day!"

End of part 4.

Part 5

"What?"

"I am not in the habit of repeating myself! You heard me." She paused, there was an audible sound of a deep draw of breath. "Adora. Not only have you failed doing the simplest of tasks, you have managed to have your brother engaged to a Gold digger of the worst kind! This is NOT what your father would have wanted! She will leave us barescraped!"

"...I do have my own money, Aunt Sharon."

"Pah. That girl will be a bad influence on you as well. I know the type! She has no limits!"

"Have you even met her?"

"She is young and Irish. They're all socialistic Catholic scum."

I suppose this wasn't the best time to tell her that so was Mermista and Sea-Hawk. Catholics, that is.

"Adora. This is all your fault."

"MY Fault?"

"You said you had the situation under control. Either you failed to stop your brother from seeing anyone or you have something to do with setting them up in some kind of backwards way of dealing with things. Not important. YOU will take care of this. Or you will be the next mrs Nightfire."

The idea that there had been precious mrs Nightfires gave me chills right to the bone.

Sometimes I wonder if Aunt Sharon even knows that other people have feelings. When she heard the old bard quote, you know the one: If you prick us, do we not bleed? If you tickle us, do we not

laugh? If you poison us, do we not die?, her answer must have been "And?"

By the time I had gotten back inside of myself, she had already ended the call. I stood there shaking in my undergarments, which was just an expression, since I had not had time to put any one. Once I finally stopped shaking, I called for Catra.

“Catra!”

Instantly she materialized in front of me.

“Miss Greyskull? I take it that the old witch must have tried to curse you?”

“Catra… Well, in a way but…” I swallowed, then I grabbed her shoulders and shook her.

“Catra! Adam is getting married!” She freed herself from my grip and nodded.

“I read the notice in the times this morning, miss Greyskull. Although I must correct you slightly, he is but getting engaged, at the moment. However, I have taken the liberty to suggest a few dresses for the occasion. You may need to consider your outfit carefully, I believe that he wants you as his best maid.”

I took the paper in question and found the proclamation. It was just as what you would suspect, with the family armour and our motto in the head (Omnes ad honorum), the announcement (Someone got engaged) a time (Last thursday), the people intending tying the old knot (Adam and Teela) and a handwritten wish for me to be his best maid (Adora! Please be my best maid) I looked at Catra. “Who did this scribble on the paper?”

“His Lordship had forgotten to put it in the add, miss. I took the liberty to follow his instructions.”

“So he called YOU.”

“No miss, he sent a telegram.”

I just threw the times away.

“Catra! Again you are focusing on the wrong matters completely! Adam! Is planning to Get. Married! To Teela!” Catra coughed discreetly.

“I beg your pardon, but I would say that that is the entire matter to focus on.”

“No! Look one step beyond! Aunt Sharon will… will….She will…” I am ashamed to admit that I turned into a weeping puddle on the floor. “She threatens to marry me off and I know her… She will do it! Catra… I can’t! Not again! I can’t live without you, please! Please…Help me…”

She took me in her embrace and stroke my (slightly longer than last week which might have made her more positive towards me) hair. “Miss Greyskull. I assure you, that I will do anything in my power to stop that arrangement, and it helps impeccably that we know about her threat beforehand. But at the moment, you must calm down and not get ahead of yourself. There are a few possibilities but right now…”

“Wait and see?”

“I would’ve said ‘lets see how things develop’ miss. May I put your attention towards the fact that Lord Ordac is a force to be counted on in the matter?”

“Uncle Howard!" I ejaculated with a sneer

"He is the one who insisted on Adam getting married. And the daughter of an admiral is a perfect suitor.”

“May so be, miss, but she is… composite. Perhaps if he will get the opportunity to meet the young lady…”

"Oh! Oh yes! Yes I see! If he should meet Teela… and in the most wild of situations… He will insist that Adam finds someone else! Yes! Thank you so much Catra!"

I grabbed her head and kissed her violently. She glared at my hair part of the time but she did not push me away this time. Ah, to kiss lips as sweet as hers! I understand her kisses as thou mine, and that's a feeling… something something Shakespeary.

I needed time to prepare, and no one really has this kind of gathering on a weekday, but I couldn't allow myself to wait for too long, as it would give Aunt Sharon time to boil over.

I suggested to Catra that we should arrange a luncheon for the happy couple and Uncle Howard by Tuesday. She bowed and said that she would have time to finish the arrangements by then.

I sent a Telegram to Adam with my best wishes and the invitation and the answer came with the returning wire. They would be delighted to come!

I suppose a letter would have been more suitable to Uncle Howard, but a telegram had to make do. I simply said I wanted to invite him to meet Adam and his future spouse on neutral ground. That sounded omniscient enough. As I left the telegram office, a thought struck me. Perhaps I should add some more dirt into the machinery? I mean, I suppose Teela could try to be her most well-behaved self but I knew that sometimes all it took to break a good spirit was something irritating enough. Like for instance, my Aunt Janice. Perfectly nice, unless the weather report and the actual weather doesn't measure up. On those days, and considering the Times' meteorologist, there are plenty, you can't even tell her to have a nice day.

The question was, what would bring Uncle Howard to such a rage?

Anything really, was the short answer. But there had to be more specific things… He didn't particularly like me. But he doesn't like

relatives over all. He doesn't like sweet wines, but Catra would never agree to only serve that with every meal. "Always dry to the main course, miss Greyskull." Alright then… He doesn't like women, but he doesn't really fancy men either… And then it came to me.

Lady Entrapta. It's not as if no one likes her, but she is rather peculiar. And above anything, Uncle Howard HATES peculiar people. That would nail it all. I sent a telegram inviting her. It took me a while to find a reason, but she had mentioned something about 'observing people' and uncle Howard was probably worth observing. She accepted on Monday afternoon, exactly one hour after uncle Howard. I rubbed my hands. This was going really well! And it had been my idea!

As I walked home from the princess club that afternoon I passed that very same barber that had done my hair previously. I thought to myself, why not show Catra that I was not under her thumb? And indeed, I was not! So I went in and had it trimmed.

I could see on her face that she wished she could make me that pea soup, and although it stung, she had to learn!

Well, Tuesday came and after a rather silent breakfast, uncle Howard arrived. Only now did it occur to me that I would have to spend time with him before my guests arrived! It would be… Something indeed.

I suppose I should take a moment to describe him. He is as you could expect as relatives of me are, tall and slim, even if his age has made him stoop forward a little. He is bald and his face has sunken in, making him look a bit skullish or something a little bit batty. As he spends 99% of his time inside, he is quite pale, and there are wounds on his hands that I think are the results of his experiments, but it could just be hot coffee as well. Save for the head, the only piece of his body we ever see is his hands. Long, slim and pale, with rather sharp nails. I swear, if his eyes had

been red, I would have sworn him to be a vampire. But I have seen him in the middle of the day and I know he eats yoghurt. I do say, had the film people seen uncle, Mr Lugosi would have not been as successful. He has a shadow of a goatee, but the most impressive things are his sideboards, which are still pitch black and make his head look like it's been framed. His teeth, when he chooses to bare them, are porcelain white and his piercing eyes are light green. He constantly wears small pines-neez but he spends most of the time looking at you over the brim of them.

As he did with me at that very moment, on my own couch.

"well well well, Uncle Howard! Lovely day isn't it?"

"Hmpf. The humidity is ten percent above the bearable level."

"Oh. Bummer."

"And the water holds a pH number of 5.7."

I blinked. "Oh. Is that bad?"

He gave me a dry look."well it's not good if you were of that impression!"

"Oh. Well. Um… yes. But speaking of humidity, perhaps you would fancy a drink before the others arrive?"

"Was that an attempt to be funny?"

Uncle Howard gave me another dissaproving look over the rim of his pincene. I say, he must be the last person in England to wear that.

"Oh no! Not at all."

"Good. And yes, thank you. I hope that servant girl of you can mix a decent gin and tonic. As dry as you can get it!"

I rushed out of the room to find Catra. I can mix a drink myself but even her cold shoulder was inviting compared to Uncle Howard.

She of course had the drinks ready, and handed me the tray without any unnecessary words

"Gin and tonic, extra dry for his Lordship. Angostura bitter for you, miss Greyskull. Would that be all, miss?"

"Um… yes. yes. Will we have kippers?"

"...Yes miss Greyskull. We will."

"Good! Good…"

Catra disapproves of kippers on a principal level but when Lord Ordac is in town, even she has to bend. A little.

" Um. Catra."

"Yes, Miss Greyskull?"

The look she gave me told me I don't care if you are scared of your uncle, I am busy and get out of my kitchen! So I grabbed the drinks and went out to Uncle Howard.

He looked at it skeptically, sniffed it a bit and finally tasted it.

"Hm. Adequate."

"Oh. Good."

"Don’t draw any conclusion. Just because it is drinkable doesn’t mean I enjoy the taste."

"Ah. Alright then. Well, then. So! Um. Have you heard if Blackburn won their latest game?"

"What game?"

"Cricket."

"No. Sports is a waste of time." What an old ass! But a Greyskull doesn't give up that Easily!

"Alright. Ehm. Anyway. Uncle Howard. How are things?"

"What things?"

"Well, you know…Life in General?"

"I prefer not to speak about general things. As a scientist I prefer to be specific."

"Oh. Ah. Well… How are your legs?"

"Working."

"Jolly good! Jolly good! And your arms?"

"Functional."

"Oh really? And your head?"

"I feel a headache coming up."

"Blimey! Why?"

"You keep talking to me. Please be quiet. The only thing sensible about you is your hair, and I have my suspicions that you made it look like that by accident."

I felt it was better to hold my tongue for a bit. I never believed uncle Howard to be the first to kind of compliment my hair, but I didn't really think I would score any points with Catra if I mentioned that.

So there we were, gently sipping on our drinks. I tried a few. "I say." Or "What ho?" And even "tooddles!" But Uncle made little

reaction save for grunts. Finally I said "So, Uncle. Your latest experiments…"

"I doubt that you would understand the intricacies of modern chemistry, Adora."

"I say, Uncle Howard!"

"Alright, let us see then. Are you aware that the body consists of around 65% of DiHydrogenOxide?"

"By Jove! Isn't that dangerous?" He grunted and blinked.

"It's water, Adora. Please, withhold every other attempt at conversation. It does not become you and makes you look like a gutted fish."

I closed my mouth and concentrated on my drink. Once it was finished I fled to Catra for another one.

"Catra! I can't stand this anymore. Where is Adam?"

"His Lordship rung for approximately ten minutes ago, miss Greyskull. The train had ran a little late but they tried to find a cab. They should be here within the next quarter of an hour, miss."

"A quarter…"

"as I said, Miss."

"It feels like forever! I have nothing to talk to Uncle Howard about. Nothing. Even Lady Entraptas company would have been preferable."

Catra raised an eyebrow. "Her Ladyship have already arrived, miss."

"What?"

She dried her hands on the apron. "Yes, Miss Greyskull. She arrived about ten minutes ago. I informed her that you were in the salon. She didn’t need me to introduce her, Miss Greyskull, she said it usually worked better if she was discreet."

"And you didn't care to warn me?"

"My apologies, miss." No, she was not. And I hoped that Lady Entrapta hadn't made my uncle lose his temper before he was supposed to!

I ran out to the salon. At first I didn’t see Lady Entrapta, but the I found her hiding behind the chaise lounge, scribbling like crazy and murmuring to herself. "Blonde woman disappeared 4 minutes ago. Her unsuccessful attempts at polite conversation got her uneasy, possible explanation for her leaving? Old grey man has been holding on to his drink for the better of 25 minutes. That is the second longest time observed yet…"

I sat down on the fitment in question, trying my best to imitate Catras patented cough. When that didn’t render me any response I gave up. "What ho, En…Lady Entrapta?"

She looked up. "Oh, please don’t let me disturb you, miss Greyskull. I am observing your interactions." I let my eyes glide around the room with some uneasiness.

"Ah. Well… um… Actually, I would prefer it if you just sat down and had a drink."

"But the data! The science!"

"Can’t the data wait?"

She stared at me as if I had suggested England to become a republic. "You must ALWAYS honor the DATA!"

"...Alright but..m science! Science! You know, Lady Entrapta, my Uncle, Lord Ordac is a bit of a scientist himself! You probably have

a lot of things in common! Sit! Sit down and I will get you a drink!"

"Oh! A scientist you say…" She let the word play on her tongue like she was tasting a fine wine. "Interesting… Can I get a tiny glass of a vodka Lime?"

"Um… sure…"

I left the room to execute the order, but of course Catra had already prepared it. The glass was not bigger than an egg cup.

"What ho, Catra?"

"I was in her Ladyships service for two months, miss. I know how she prefers her food and drink. Now, if you excuse me…"

I got the hint and left. I found Lady Entrapta in conversation with my uncle. She conversated, he looked slightly in pain.

"...and that's how I learned never to work with hydrochloric acid and Sodium without at least removing the carpets first! But that is the beauty of science! Even failures are a way to learn! Don't you agree?"

Uncle Howard made a face as if he considered throwing up on her Ladyship but in the end he condescended himself ro answer.

"I never fail. At times there are hypothesises that doesn't hold up to scrutiny, but I will not allow that to be called failure."

If that was meant to get Lady Entrapta to back of, it failed.

"Excellent! That's an even better expression! I LIKE you, Howard!"

I am PRETTY sure, they had not exchanged titles… but luckily Uncle Howard had no time to explode because then Adam and Teela entered.

"Hello Adora!"

“Hi Miss Greyskull! Or, could I call you Adora? I mean, we will soon both be Greyskulls anyway, aight?”

“Oh! Oh sure! Sure, old gal! Adora Swordhand at your service.”

“Teela Vanguard at yours.” Vanguard? Alright, yes. Fitting.

“So, well, lets go at sit down, shall we? I believe that dinner is ready and…Yes. We will start with kippers.”

“Kippers?” Adam gave me that goldfish face that always makes him look so silly. But Teela clapped her hands in excitement. “Kippers! fried, perhaps?” I shrugged my shoulders, I had no real idea how Catra could make that edible. I turned around only to find myself face to face with Lady Entrapta. “Oooh, siblings! Twins even! It is interesting how you tend to choose similar dispositions and outfits at the same time as trying your best to be individuals. Perhaps you have read my little monograph on the subject? But that is old news, now YOU!” she turned to Teela (and Adam, apparently.) She walked up to Teela, sniffed a little, felt her hair, and then she did the same with Adam. “You don’t share a bed, you have separate toilets and one of you uses a kind of soap you are allergic to. A bit disappointing, you are in the most dull part of a mating ritual. Give me a call once you have decided you actually like each other and I could add you to participants in my research about english couples being… Oh… OH! YOU are IRISH!”

Teela gave Lady entrapta that mixed look of surprise and uncomfort that she usually emulates when she forgets about personal space. “Yeees….?”

“That changes EVERYTHING!”

And she began to scribble something in her little book. I took the opportunity to lead her to the table. Today, by the way, she wore an electrician's leather vest over a red evening frock. And boots. I could imagine Catra needing a breather as she entered, but it’s very much Lady Entrapta.

Uncle Howard had already sat down and Catra entered.

“For starters, Kippers marinated in olive oil, red vinegar and just a breath of garlic, fried and served on white bread.” Uncle Howard huffed, and he showed no sign of approval (he ate four, but I think that is because he wasn’t paying.) Lady Entrapta cut her fish in the tiniest pieces before eating them. One hand writing notes, the other busy with the food and I swear that once it actually looked like a piece of her hair held her wine glass.

Adam and Teela and myself found Catras handling of the fish superb, and we amiably chatted about nothings. Uncle Howard glared at us from time to time but said nothing. I kept my eyes on the couple, there was no sign of intimacy between them, not what I could see, and apparently neither did Lady Entrapta. But there was some sort of understanding between them, we managed to have a conversation about Tennis that went a little deeper than polite. As a tenniser, I am more than well acquainted with the polite way a non tennisser discuss the matter.

“Oh, you managed a fine backhand? Well, I say!” or “Ah, you won by fifth set? Splendid”

or even “You know, that net seems to get awfully in the way a lot for you people, is it not?”

People I say! It takes a true tenisser to understand the difference between bagel and bageled. Lucky for me, Adam and teela was the latter sort.

As Catra cleaned the table and made room for “Boeuf Bourguignon with pressed potatoes' ', again there came a huff from Uncle. Foreign food is not his cup of tea, a cup of tea would be better than any of that. I could only suspect that Catra had a secret plan, where she would make uncle annoyed and in his annoyance, force Adam and Teela to call it all off! She really is brilliant!

As I said, Uncle Howard had been leering at us for most of the meal and now he couldn’t keep his mouth shut any longer.

“I understand that you are interested in sport, miss… Saltire.”

“I am indeed.”

“Yes. Rather quite the waste of time for a young woman, isn’t it?”

I bit my lip, just waiting for Teela to raise her voice. She didn’t, but there was a noticeable frost in her voice, that early, biting type that hits you right in the nose the second you exit the club.

“I see. Well, a lot of people are interested in sports. Even young men.”

“Yes, it is most unfortunate that the young generation waste their time.”

“I myself think it is a sound quality for everyone that wants to stay healthy.”

“That is nothing a proper diet doesn’t provide.”

“Oh really. So what do you eat then, your lordship?”

“I am not the subject of this discussion.”

“But I am?”

“Most certainly.”

I saw Teela shoot arrows from her eyes, and she clunged her knife in a way that I knew Catra wouldn’t approve of. She always say that the fork is a more devilish weapon, should violence at a table ever occur.

“But I suppose you can not eat all the time?”

“I indeed hope not. That would make you look fat and stupid. The worst combination in a woman.”

“YOUR Lordship… Ehrm. Excuse me.” Damn. She HAS been well-bred. I have to admit I imagined the daughter of an admiral to be

more wild, but on the other hand, I only know Sea-hawk and perhaps he is not representative for any type of person really. “I would say that even a young man can look fat and stupid.”

“It is possible, but the fat young man usually has something to add.”

“And that is?”

“Science.”

“I… I beg your pardon?” I think we all looked at uncle Howard with questions in our eyes, save for Lady Entrapta. She had three note books out now, and I think she had asked Catra for another cocktail because the was sipping something small and sparkling.

“Well. You see, the young fat man is usually something of a genius. It happens occasionally that is is only the food, but most of the time, in that young mans quarters you find books. You find posters. Maps. Maybe even laboratory equipment. He may lack a variety of interests and he should hire a different chef, but there is certainly nothing wrong with his brain!”

Only now did I notice that I had a loaded fork halfway to my mouth. Even if I somewhat wanted my uncle to uncle, it still was rather unpleasant. I tried to collect myself and raised it further,proceeding to take the content in my mouth, but in the excitement I forgot to chew and I had a few uncomfortable moments before Catra arrived with a glass of water. I must say that I do appreciate that she doesn't want to see me dead at least. Uncle Howard glared at me and I could see that unfortunately I had also managed to cool Teela down a little. Drats. But now, Entrapta decided to say something.

“This is FASCINATING, Howard! I would LOVE to see your data on this subject! I myself have studied the matter somewhat, I have been a tutor to quite a few young people over the years (I always forget that Lady Entrapta is at least ten years my senior) and I

have to say that I have not accounted for the fat coefficient in that!”

“Ah yes. You call yourself a scientist, mylady.”

“I AM a scientist.”

“...I acknowledge that you have published a few monographs… of which you have shown me three… but I must say, one can not be a proper scientist if you don’t limit yourself.”

If he expected Lady Entrapta to take offense, she didn’t.

“But why? When there is so much in this world to know! To measure! To observe!”

“Yes, yes, but there has to be one subject you hold higher than everything else.”

“Oh yes! Certainly!”

“And that is?”

“EVERYTHING!” Her eyes shone like all of Glimmer's moms silver placed side by side on a table at noon with the curtains drawn.

“You… you can not seriously mean that.”

“YES! Everything is interesting and deserves attention! Sociology, physics, astronomy, chemistry…”

“LADY ENTRAPTA! I will give you the credit that you are using the correct terms but this is not the way to speak about chemistry! The most noble of sciences deserves… our respect… our devotion. Our everything!”

“Yesyes yes! All that but there is so much you can learn if you compare your interests! And notes! I am certain that most of your experiments would gain to be compared to a wider field.”

“Oh. THIS DOES IT!”

Uncle Howard stood up. “I have endured the wicked food, the brainless conversation with our host and the rudeness and vulgarity of the young generation of women but YOU, lady Entrapta is too much for a man to TAKE! I forbid you to ever speak to me again and if you come near my equipment I will show you how a proper scientist deals with filisteens! GOOD DAY!”

He walked briskly out of the room. “AND ADAM, I FORBID YOU TO MARRY THAT WOMAN. ANY WOMAN!”

From the hall I heard Catra “Should I call your lordship a cab?”

“No. I will do it myself on the street. I can take no further interactions with women. TO HELL WITH WOMEN!” I heard him scream until the door closed.

End of part 5

Part 6

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

As Lady Entrapta violently continued to scribble down her notes, I decided to take Adam aside.

“Look here, old chap. This… This... I must say. It’s really quite a..." He interrupted me, resignated. Definitely a...alright, not a good sign for his mood, but a definite sign that my plan had worked.

“Just say it right out. Today was a mess.”

“I wouldn’t use such wording, actually.”

“What would you say then?”

“Something akin to ‘interesting’?”

Adam shook his head. “Don’t, Adora. Please don’t. It doesn’t suit you to be subtle. Or trying to be.”

I nodded. “I won't."

“Thank you. Tell Catra we are sorry that we can’t stay for drinks, but the best thing to do right now is to take our leave. This is embarrassing as it is.”

“If you say so.”

“You said it yourself, more or less.”

“Blimey. I wasn’t trying!”

He placed a hand on my shoulder. “Bless your heart, Adora. And not like they mean in the south of Texas.”

“What do they mean in the south?”

“Something opprobrious. Let’s leave it at that.”

“Ah. Yes.”

“I expect Catra to make sure that we will leave with as much decorum and discretion as possible. Could you please talk to her about that?”

“Oh! Oh yes of course old boy!”

“Good. I don’t think Teela really gets the gravity of the moment.”

“Ah. Teela. Yes. I suppose it was fun while it lasted.”

He gave me a rather peculiar look.” What do you mean?”

“Well, I mean… The engagement.”

“What about it?”

“Well, I mean… Uncle Howard didn’t exactly approve, wouldn’t you say?”

The same peculiar look. “so?”

“Well… It’s not like you could keep the engagement then?”

“Adora.” he shook his head. “I understand that you are not the biggest fan of marriage and that you are looking for excuses but I honestly care silch about what Uncle Howard thinks.”

“But…but… he is a lord!”

“So am I, Adora.”

“Oh. Oh yes.”

“And Lord Grayskull trumps Lord Ordac. And even if that was not the case, I am a Greyskull. And a gentleman. And a gentleman

and a Greyskull always stays by his word. …If she is pleased with having me as a husband, this alters nothing." He paused and shot Teela a glance. "Yes...If she is pleased... Now, could you please talk to Catra? Before Lady Entrapta and my fiance bonds more over strategies for long distance running…. brr.”

I stared at him, but I turned on my foot to talk to Catra. She of course had already prepared the ladies coats and my brother's hat, and sent them away from the old lair with a few mumbled pleasantries while I let my chin fall as much as it’s heart wished.

Catra soon materialized next to me.

“Would you like me to put the leftovers in the fridge, miss Greyskull? It would be a shame to let the rest of the boeuf and the cake go to waste.”

“Oh… Oh yes… let it all…go to waste…”

“Miss Greyskull?”

“I… this is… I don’t…even…”

She caught me and poured me down on the sofa. The next moment there was a whiskey in my hand. I did not take it in one go, I drank it slowly with afterthought, to make sure that this was really happening. Catra returned after having dealt with the lost dinner. And Lady Entrapta, who she finally managed to get away from the table and out of the flat. I don’t think she stopped writing that whole time. I did hear her tell Catra “What an interesting man! I can’t wait to see his results!” What Catra replied I didn’t hear.

“You seem upset, miss Greyskull.”

“Oh. What gave you that impression?” She frowned.

“I take it that the dinner did not have the result you hoped for?”

“Hoped for? It was beyond every fear I had! Catra! Adam is not going to break the engagement!”

“Really, miss?”

“Really! He says that Uncle Howard can go to a warm place for all he cares, he won’t break off anything. Darn it all, I didn’t count for him to be that much of a gentleman.”

“I see, miss Greyskull.”

“Now what should I do? I don’t have any ideas left.”

“My apologies, miss Greyskull.”

“And you can’t come up with anything? We did have kippers after all, Catra.”

With a quick glance towards my hair, she replied “At the moment I have nothing to say, miss.”

I can’t believe her! She understands the situation perfectly well, she knows what pressure we are under and yet, even then, she let's her views on my hair get in between us! To hell with her, I say! Well, I didn’t but I would had I not been so well raised. Catra extracted her usual discreet cough.

“Perhaps you should search for wisdom in literature, miss Greyskull? I believe that Goethe has written some quite interesting passages on the matter.”

“Goethe can go swim in the Rheine, Catra!”

“I believe he probably swam in the Maine, more than the Rhine, Miss.” Oh, we can't help, but we can correct! I see!

“I don’t care! Rhine, Maine, Oder, whatever! I don’t want anything German!”

“In that case, miss, perhaps I might suggest another classic? Some Classic Shakespeare? Or maybe Sir Montgomery Rodden?”

“Burn all Blank Verse. I had enough of that in school.”

“Very well miss. Perhaps you would enjoy something a bit more contemporary then? Not exactly something edifying, but it might entlist you some entertainment?”

“I have already read all the Christies, Catra.”

“I did not refer to the works of Mrs. Christie Mallowan, Miss Greyskull. I am talking about your own brother. Or ‘Melvyn Kemppf’ as his nome de plume is.”

“Melvyn Kemppf?”

“I believe he found the name on a bottle of ketchup once, miss.”

“Ah. Oh alright. It’s not like it could make things worse.” I did manage to get through ten volumes of Mer-misteries on Mistas insistence so I guess I could give my brothers work at least a glance.

“I don’t expect you that you could recommend one for me, Catra?”

“My personal favourite is “He-man and the Snake King”, Miss.” I stared at her.

“YOU read that kind of stuff?” She coughed again.

“It is important to stay a jour with the current talk of the town, miss. Your brother is quite successful.”

“...Oh. Alright then!.” I had very little hope but the fact that Catra could recommend it at least gave me some hope that it wouldn't be a complete waste of my time. But the joke was on me! I spent the rest of Tuesday, a good part of Wednesday and Thursday morning reading. I have to say, now that I actually made the

effort to read, my brother had a… certain way with words. It's not elegant, but it held a certain weight, and there was quite often a whoosh that catapulted the story forward. And He-man was a rather sympathetic chap, actually. I would expect a man that wears some kind of fur skin as unmentionables would be an unscrupulous brute but he was rather a gentleman who only used his sword when he had to. And that King Hiss was one heck of a nasty piece of wood, I say! I cheered when He-man… Ah well, I won't spoil the ending for you. I called for Catra.

"Catra!"

She floated in from the kitchen. "Yes, miss Greyskulll?"

"You don't possibly have another volume? I did enjoy this, very much actually." She bowed.

"In that case, let me bring you "He-man and the Skeletor." It introduces the foil for many of the books in a most dramatic way, Miss Greyskull. However, perhaps I should suggest that you wait until later to start reading, miss."

"Huh? What ho?"

"You have fencing with Miss Saltire planned, miss."

"Huh. I imagined that she had more or less built a nest in Ramsgate."

"She *is* a sportswoman, Miss Greyskull."

"Ah yes. Say no more."

"Indeed I won't miss Greyskull. Are you planning to have lunch at the club?"

"...Yes, I think I will!"

"Very well, miss. Please inform me if you require dinner." I was in fact not. I felt the pea soup close in on me. On my walk to the

club I had my brothers writing all over my mind. I can not write, not in the slightest. I got the muscles, he got the talent, but you won't see my lips quiver over that! I have never felt the urge to brag about my successful brother, but it is partly because he doesn't want me to. The scandal, that a lord writes such books!

I stopped dead in my tracks. The scandal! That a Lord! Writes such books! Of course! Why hadn't I thought about that! And Adam said that he had doubts about her being satisfied with him! There it was, bright as daylight! There was no way that Teela would accept a man writing such books! As capturing as they were, they could hardly be called suitable or upbringing!

Now, I have to say, I wasn't doing this with a light heart, far from it! But 1. I didn't want to be married. 2. Adam and Teela would be sad for a while and then life would move on. He would eventuelly find someone. And Teela would… yes. It would all end up well. There was the money… Eh. Adam just had to write better books.

Even if I had my mind made up, I couldn't really bring myself to tell her myself. And even if I could've, that would not be befitting for a Greyskull. This needed to be handed with tact and decorum! I could ask someone… But who? Not Glimmer, she would ask questions. Not Mermista, she would just be to blunt… Or glare at me. Or both. And Catra had made it clear that she wouldn't lift a finger.

But then it struck me! I could write an anonymous letter! And put it in her locker as we changed for fencing. That did happen to me once, it said 'Adora Greyskull is a mindless twit'. It was awfully awkward to receive. How wouldn't it feel if a truth was delivered that way? Twice the awkwardness! So what if Catra wasn't going to help me, this could NOT go wrong! I locked myself in the writing room at the club while I authored the note in question. I had to be subtle yet cheeky. In the end, I settled for

'Do you know that your fiancee writes the He-man books? That's not really cricket, is it?'

That ought to do it. Then I met Teela in the changing room and as she went to a certain place before the match, I sneaked it in her locker. The match was even, but I have to say that she has a certain skill with the blade! In the end, she won, but I was not far behind! After the match I excused myself that I needed to call Catra, but that I would wait for her in the dining hall. I ordered two plat du jour for us and a bottle of red wine while I waited. The long face she presented me with did not disappoint, this was a woman who had had a great shock!

"I say, Teela! Why the long sudden face?"

She sat down, and poured herself a glass, and emptied it in one go.

"Adora. You know your brother well, don't you?"

"Well, he is my brother."

"Yes yes. But… D'yer know 'bout 'is writing?" I noticed her irish getting thicker as she got upset.

I made a meaningful gesture to look down. "Ah. Well, um… AS the matter of fact I do."

"Yer knew dat 'e is Melwyn Kemppf. De author of 'He-man an' de masters of de universe'?"

"No point in denying it I see, old lass. Yes, I knew."

"It's true then. It is really really true."

"I am sorry my dear. But yes."

She stared at nothing, then she had another glass. Then she rose from the table. "Thank you Adora. I can't stay. I need to… I need to find a garage. I need a Car."

"Teela! What ho?"

“Adora. I need to go to Ramsgate. Now.”

“Ah. Well, Toodle-oo!” But she didn’t even pip pip back to me, so hurried was she! And there was I, left with two plat du jour. Luckily, fencing always gives me an appetite but the meal came with a slight side taste of regret. Ah well, it was done. All I had to do was to wait for the inevitable. And I did not want a double marriage, no I didn't.

The inevitable came with the Friday post. A short letter from Adam. “Adora. I will visit you, Monday lunch. I have something really important to tell you.”I jumped on the phone to invite Aunt Sharon. I wanted her to see this so she would stop bugging me about the whole business.

End of part 6.

Chapter End Notes

Only one chapter left...

Part 7

Chapter Notes

> And so we end this happy little tale!
>
> It's been a while, quite a long while since the penultimate chapter, and I deeply apologize for that. I was waiting for an illustration. But life got in the way of my artist and I felt that I couldn't really keep you from reading for so long. So, here it is. One day in the future I will update with a little bonus chapter and the image but for now... The curtain rises for the last part! What will happen? Will Adam get married? Does Adora HAVE to marry? What is Lady Entraptas next experiment? And what has Catra been doing all this time? Stay tuned and you may find out...

Monday came, but before it did, I had to make two visits to Plumeria for a little rendez-vous, as the french says, with Swift Wind to cool my nerves down during the inbetween days. It is interesting that, nothing clears one's mind as flying through the woods with 1800 pounds of purebred stallion under you, in front of you and behind you! And not only that but there is not a better companion when there's a lot of rannygazoo going on! Especially when the person you expect to side with you and comfort you doesn't! As I mentioned earlier, I had believed Catra to be all on team Greyskull after the luncheon but apparently I miscalculated. Now, I must clarify, that, there is nothing to complain about Catra's service to me, there is always a cocktail ready even before I ask, I can always count on a filled nosebag at any time I ask for it, my wardrobe is impeccable (although I have noticed her being rather keen on me sporting a hat lately…) But there is not that little extra special love for Adora that shines through in rough times. And she accepts only a quick peck on the cheek. If I only could understand what I have done to her. Other than the hair! Well, as I said to Swift Wind, that will only make my triumph taste even sweeter, come Monday! And he answered, like he always does, 'Right you are, Adora'. …Alright, maybe he doesn't speak in

that precise manner… but that is the gheist of it! And yes, I might be reading too much into it, but he does know when I am upset! He always strokes his muzzle against my chin and hair in that slow, calming way that cats do. Or is it dogs? Or was it ferrets? Ah well, that doesn't matter. I was invited to tea with Perfuma on Sunday, but I declined. She is so calm it makes me nervous at times.

Looking at what I just said, I seem to be stalling again. Ah yes. Monday.

So, Aunt Sharon arrived around a quarter to eleven. I offered her lunch but she said that she was already invited to lunch with some members of the Tory party afterwards.

"Ah. Well, I hope it will be enjoyable."

"It most certainly will not. They are dreadful people who do nothing but spread nasty gossip."

"Why then have lunch with them?"

"Because otherwise the Gossip will be about me."

Ah. It's pretty much what I expect from Aunt Sharon, no friends, only snooters. Anway, we sat down with tea and a few biscuits. I do say, I wouldn't have minded a cocktail but with Aunt Sharon around… I sat as on nails, I just wanted this to be over with. I expected nothing but success after Adams telegram, but that success did not taste as good as it was supposed to, no. But It would taste better than the wedding dinner I would have to swallow if I failed.

Catra passed through the room from time to time, refilling our cups or putting something in its right place. But nothing about my brother. I should have expected it I suppose, but time was running towards 11.25 and if I had one more cup the rest of the day would be spent in a different room than the salon. And after the fifth time I asked, this was Catra's answer,

“No, miss Greyskull. His Lordship and Miss Teela have not arrived yet, neither have they telephoned. Would you perhaps want me to take my crossbow and go hunt for them?” No point asking anymore.

But finally, at 11.50 they arrived. There was quite the hullabaloo in the hall before they entered. I had expected a quiet and slightly melancholy Adam. And I had not expected Teela to be there at all! But Adam was shining like the thousand suns of Eternia (that Hyperbole had stayed on my mind since I read his book.) and Teela was… More Teela-Teela than just Teela like last time.

“ADORA! AD… Oh, hullo Aunt Sharon! I didn’t expect you!”

“The pleasure is all yours, Adam.”

“Well then! Since you’re both here, I can save the stamps and tell you right away. I AM GETTING MARRIED!”

I saw the eyebrows rise above the glasses of Aunt Sharon and there was a hollow in the veil that had to be a wide open mouth.

I am afraid I looked very much the same. When I finally managed to talk, I stuttered “Y-yes… You are eng-gaged after all.”

Adam pulled me up from the sofa and embraced me. “yes yes, but that was mostly for form. We had a date set far away because at that time I was not sure about this. But now I am, it all fell into place on Thursday! And it is all thanks to you!!”

"What!!?"

“What?” Aunt Sharon added with so much venom in her voice I swear every cobra in every zoo in the world got jealous.

“You wrote the letter to Teela telling her about my books. It was exactly what I needed!”

“It was? ….really?”

“Yes! I must say, Teela has been a most welcome addition to my life. She has energy, she has passion, she has red hair… that floats in the wind… Slowly I began to see that you were right when you said she was the perfect match for me. And slowly she overcame her shyness and showed me the real her!”

I had to say, to me, Teela seemed the same,but I guess that’s another writer's thingy.”

“Yes, Adora. I was a bit suspicious when you mentioned your brother to me, but I have no regrets left. I am glad to have found him, he will win daddy's heart as fast as he won mine. And it’s all thanks to you, sister in Law!”

“I… I… Um… right… Yes…”

“But there was one thing… the books. I was convinced that no woman would love a man who writes adventure novels set in the far land of Eternia, where men were warriors and women were warriors and Cats were battle-cats!”

“You were wrong, Addie.”

“I sure were, Titit!”

A little part of me cheered, this was so lovely! But the bigger part of me covered in fear.

“But you saw my predicament and gave Teela the hint. I knew you had to pretend to be against it so we wouldn’t suspect you, but it was obvious.”

“How? “

“I know your handwriting.”

“Oh.”

“Well, We can’t stay any longer! We have a wedding dress and a Tux to try. Sunday in two weeks, save the date, both of you! And

Adora! I want you as my best maid! Pip-Pip, Adora!”

And out the door went He-man and left me with the dreadful dragon of the depth of death. At this moment, I had never had a stronger wish for a sword. This was one of those moments where the words “look into the eyes of death and smile” would be fitting, but that was unfortunately impossible, since a) I was as such a loss for words that I couldn’t form the mouth to anything save for being wide open and b) Aunt sharon's glasses makes it impossible to see her eyes.

I had no doubt that my instant demise was on aunt Sharon's mind, as she slowly turned her eyes away from the part of the room where Adam and Teela had disappeared and towards me.

“Adora… You…You…”

“Cretin?”

“NO! THAT IS A WAY TO KIND WAY TO DESCRIBE YOU, YOU ABSOLUTE DIMWIT OF A SAD EXCUSE FOR A HUMAN BEING! AMOEBAS HAVE MORE BRAIN AND SPINE THAN YOU!” She paused to take a breath because even when angry, Aunt Sharon was of the opinion that you always have to keep some decorum, even when chewing someone out. “When I am done with you, the name Greyskull will only appear on the lists of people lost and forgotten, you…”

I had more or less counted her out, but at the danger point, she appeared. My knight in her impeccable suit, my light in the darkness. Catra materialized and let out her usual discreet cough. To me, it sounded like trumpets signaling reinforcements. “Lord Ordac is here to see you, Miss Greyskull. As is Lady Entrapta. Is this a bad moment, perhaps I should ask them to return later?”

I shook my head vigorously. “Oh no! No No, bring them in! In fact, throw them if they shouldn’t be quick enough.”

And in came the oddest couple ever. Uncle Howard looked like a well dressed undertaker as always, but there was a small change,

a brouche, romb-shaped and purple, adorned his chest on the left side. And on his arm clung Lady Entrapta, as always in a 'unique' toilet. This time it was a purple evening gown, high heels and a white lab-coat. And her eternal pink safety glasses…

"Ah. Adora. My dear child. How wonderful that you are here." He turned to aunt Sharon. "Oh. Sharon. I didn't expect to see you? Ah well, that saves me the postage." He turned to me again. "Adora, I am more than grateful to you. That you introduced this lovely creature into my life."

"His laboratory is WONDERFUL! And his work with alkaloids and theories about the Greenhouse effect are FASCINATING!" She kissed him on the cheek. "He has promised me that we can visit the chemicum and the Gustavianum in Uppsala for our honeymoon… He is soooo romantic!"

I can't tell who was the most surprised, but aunt Sharon managed a coherent sentence first.

"Honey…moon?"

"Ah yes! Lucille and I are getting married!"

Up until now, I had never heard Lady Entraptas first name (although that did explain the "wacky lucy"-sobriquet) and at least a third of my astonishment came from there.

"OH… Umm… Blimey! That's… That's great! Jolly good! really bally good!"

"I am glad that you think so, Adora. I know I have said many words in opposition to the fairer sex but I couldn't possibly imagine a woman like Lucille. Her fearlessness, her meticulously handled notes, the exactness of her experiments and the care which she handles the pipette… It is enough to make even this old heart melt!"

"Howard is a wonderful man! He listens to ALL of my theories and he asks me QUESTIONS about them! INTELLIGENT questions!"

The happy couple shared a look of love so intense that not even Glimmer and Bow could compete.

“Of course, we won’t announce the engagement until next year. The young couple deserves their time in the spotlight. Let Adam have his wench, what do I care, with the loveliest woman by my side! We wanted you to be the first to know, Adora. But, please be silent. until it is official!”

“Of course! "Of…course!" I felt like I had to add something. “I am… really happy for you.”

“Oh and another thing. I need you to swear something!”

“Oh? Well, I say… sure!”

“Good. You must swear to never marry for anything less than love! Or else you will have me to answer to!”

I think my eyes were prepared to pop out but I managed to get something akin to ‘of course’ over my lips. “Brilliant! No one should be forced to marry without love. Don’t you agree, Sharon?”

Aunt Sharon looked like she had eaten a sack of lemons but she managed to say in the politest of ways “It is an interesting statement, Howard.”

He nodded. “Well, off we go! We need to get a new set of burners. Aaand…I have a nice little experiment prepared for my little litmus paper… Let us get Radioactive!!!

I had no idea Lady Entrapta could squee, nor that Uncle Howard could sound… flirty.

And out they went.

Aunt Sharon looked after them, then at me. “We will never speak about this again, Adora.”

“Oh. Oh no.”

"Good." And then she left herself. Once the door was closed, Catra materialized with a brandy ready. I finished it in one swift movement and sunk down on the sofa.

"Catra… Have a seat."

"That is hardly suitable, miss Greyskull."

"I don't care. I have been run over by the 3.47 from St.Pancras. Sit down and tell me what in the name of the white cliffs of Dover just happened."

"Your brother and Ms. Saltire are getting married, Miss Greyskull. The date has been slightly altered since the young couple can't wait to start a family, but there is time. I have taken the liberty to book an appointment with your hairdresser on the Friday before. Your usual hairdresser, that is."

"Yes, thank you, Catra. I think I kind of realized that."

"My apologies, miss Greyskull. Sometimes I can't help myself." She was silent but did not leave. There was tension in the air and I knew the reason.

"Catra… I have no proof, but knowing you, I am convinced that you had more than one finger in this game. Tell me all and get it over with. I have been spending the morning with aunt Sharon, I can take another dose of how much of a fool I am."

Catra coughed discreetly. "As a matter of fact, Miss Greyskull, you have handled this business very amiably. At times perhaps a slight change of direction was necessary but over all, this is pretty much your work."

"What? Really?" She nodded.

"Oh yes. Although perhaps I should say that you did it without knowing what the results would be. But, the actions and ideas were yours."

“BY JOVE!” I exclaimed, standing up.

The idea that I actually had accomplished all this made me feel a bit weak though, for the second time in this narrative, it was too much and I fainted.

When I came to, I was lying on the bed, wearing nothing more than my underskirt, upper and lower unmentionables and stockings. I had a cold, damp towel around my head and a cup of bouillon next to me. And of course, Catra.

“Ah, miss Greyskull. I am glad that you are awake.”

“Catra!” I reached for her hand. “Explain how it all is connected because even if it is true, I can’t even see the beginning of it all! How can this be my work?”

“Well, miss Greyskull. To begin with, I have to correct an error you keep making. You seem convinced that you and your brother have so very little in common. In reality, you share many traits, both personality wise and in the way you judge someone's character. Even if I was flattered that his Lordship had so high thoughts about me, I was convinced that you could probably find a better person for him to marry. And not only that, I was also convinced that what your brother said about the kind of woman he wanted, was a lie or at least not very true.”

“What? But he said…”

“Your brother may have convinced himself that he wanted someone meek and silent, but he has given himself away so many times, miss Greyskull.”

“Has he? Drats. I have never noticed.”

“You would, if you have read more of his books, Miss. It is undoubtedly so that the character of He-Man is the version of himself that he at least partly wants to be, and that the woman he wants… If you permit, I will give you an excerpt from *He-man and the slime pit of despair.* Ehrm. ‘From the moment he laid eyes on

her, He-man knew she was the one. The way her hair moved with the wind, the way she held her axe, always sharp and ready for battle. Never was he more full of joy than when she rode with him in battle, her eyes shining with excitement, never was he more proud than when she could beat him fair and square in the training rings. She was as wild and untamed as the wind and as beautiful as the brightest rose. And his heart had swelled with joy when she had chosen to join him on his journey.' Now, he does not mention the red hair explicitly but the gheist is there, I believe, Miss Greyskull."

"I say!"

"I can not see another person more suited for He-man, I mean, Lord Greyskull, than Miss Saltire. She will give your brother the firm hand he needs to improve his life. I had no doubts that attraction would occur. That was more or less a clear case. However, I realized immediately that you would never suggest her name to him, since you had written her off as impossible. I could probably convince him, but then there was the issue with Mrs Weaver. As despicable as she is, I know that you would at least try to do as she had said, and if nothing else, you would have stayed silent, and that just wouldn't do. But you had given me the perfect opportunity, miss. Now, let me make this absolutely clear. Your haircut, miss, is hideous. But I may have learned to accept it, in time. However. I am aware that you sometimes do things just to spite me. And if I would give you the cold shoulder, not only would you keep your haircut, it was more or less obvious that you would suggest as a possible sister-in-law, the one person that your brother would be happy with, in the singular belief that Miss Saltire was the worst possible choice and that she would lead to him staying a bachelor for at least five more years. All to make me mad and show me that you also could think, if you excuse my expression, miss Greyskull" I blinked. That woman knows me so well.

"...Catra… You are one in a million."

She bowed. “Thank you, miss Greyskull. I have to say, at times it was hard to keep my cold attitude, but luckily Mrs Weaver called now and then and made you sure of your plan. I did not expect you to cut your hair a second time but it did help me keep my emotions at bay. Also, in order to make you stay on the track, I overdid my aversion towards Miss Saltire a bit. In reality I find her rather an amusing person even if her vocabulary is… Sub-par. Now, with the plan rolling along rather well, the question remaining was how to deal with Mrs Weaver. I am ashamed to admit it but I may have gone a bit further than what is suitable for a person of my position. But still… Call me slow-witted if you like, Miss Greyskull, but I have not forgiven Mrs Weaver for almost forcing me to part ways with you and I have for some time been bearing the wish for a slight revenge. Do you by any chance know what her actual motive for stopping the marriage was?”

“She said that she didn’t want fathers money to get in the hands of Teela.”

“That she said, but that was not the actual reason, miss Greyskull. I had the opportunity to read your fathers will.”

“How did you… Oh don’t tell me… You know a secretary at the law firm father entlisted.”

“One of the book keepers, but yes. Fisto is not one to forget a helping hand. There was a clause about how much money you would receive. You got 100 000£ once you reached 21 years of age. His lordship, being his Lordship, got 150 000£ with the addendum that the remaining 450000 would be his on his 25th birthday, unless… He was to be found a bachelor. Then the money would be divided between the other closest relatives. Or, as you might guess…”

“No! You can’t mean that Aunt Sharon wanted me to wreck their marriage for *money* ?”

“I do mean, Miss Greyskull. 450 000 is a nifty sum. People have murdered for less.”

“I say!”

“Now, as I have said more than once, that business was rather dead on arrival if you permit the remark. Frankly, once they had met, there was very little that would put a wedge between Miss Saltire and his Lordship. I don’t want to brag about my simple abilities…”

“Catra, you are outstanding! Unequalled! Unique! Smashing!”

She bowed, with a smile this time. “Thank you, miss Greyskull. Well then, to put it frankly: *I* could have made them split up. Not you. But it was of the utmost importance that you believed so, and that Mrs Weaver believed the same. I had two alternative plans, and the first one involved his Lordship. I mean Lord Ordac. I knew that this would not change anything between them. Lord Grayskull may have been given the suggestion to marry from his lordship, but after that, he would not care much for his opinion. And miss Teela even less. No, his Lordship would not approve of her, but that would only make her more desirable to your brother.”

“Why would he?” Again she coughed.

“You and him being alike is prominent in this case. Mrs Weaver has exposed her opinions about me more than once, yet you have never given me notice but instead keeps giving me small signs of your assessment. I do my best to be at your service, miss, but I don’t think I am wrong to assume that a small part of you keeps me around to rebel against your aunt in a safe way.”

I blushed. It was not a large part of why, but she was right. Damn the woman!

“And Lord Greyskull does trumps Lord Ordac. Nevertheless your brother would definitely lean onto the idea to stand up to an authority figure, if only a symbolic one and thereby cementing his marriage plans further. Well, the dinner came and went. I have to say that I did not expect you to suggest Lady Entrapta as a guest, considering your feelings and our history but… Well, perhaps that

is to go a bit too far for now. As I said, there would not be an end to the engagement even after his Lordship leaving in the most dramatic way. Still, I had to make sure you stayed calm and to build everything up to a perfect, if you allow me to say so, sting, towards Mrs Weaver. I was convinced that she would not settle for how things were at that moment, and I was right. I wanted to push her just within reach of victory… and then take it all away."

There was a small grin playing on Catras mouth and a fire in her eyes that I have to say was awfully attractive! "Ehrm. Again, you were crucial to my plans. You hade to make mrs. Weaver believe that the whole affair could be called off. I had a conversation with you where I put some emphasis on the fact that your brother was a writer. As you were convinced, just like his Lordship, that his alternative career would make Miss Salitle change her mind, you took the bait, followed my suggestion and wrote the anonymous letter. It calmed down Mrs Weaver, and … well, you know the result. In reality, it did strengthen their bond even more. In fact, his lordship wanted her to know, even if it would risk everything."

" WHAT? I say! Really, Catra! How could you know that my brother really wanted Teela to know about it? …and how did you know that I wrote an anonymous letter?"

"Knowing you, miss, I figured that would be as you would say 'being sneaky'. And considering the first part, Well, miss Greyskull… He had actually asked me about it. He wanted to be completely open with Miss Saltire, but he couldn't possibly make himself tell her. I told him that I unfortunately found it difficult to do so but I mentioned that you had indeed noticed his predicament and was on your way to help."

"By jove! That explains… so much."

"There is no disadvantage in your brother having more faith in you, miss Greyskull.
With the letter sent, you could convince Mrs Weaver that you were doing all you could and that she wouldn't interfere. I doubt it would have made a difference but it was much neater that way.

As for the final touch, I did give you the idea to give Lord Ordac a more prominent role in the drama but it was your idea completely to insert Lady Entrapta on the scene. I have to admit, I did not see their romance coming from any angle. But you spotted it, Miss Greyskull, with your fine eye for human relations."

I was pretty sure she was giving me not only the best butter, but the whole dairy, but I am but a human. It is always nice to get praise.

"Well, I hardly need to tell you the rest. Lady Entrapta is very persistent and once I had managed to give her the address to Alarum Court and the number to Mr Grizzlor she just simply went there to 'see his lab'."

"Ah. What ho!"

"Knowing Mr Grizzlor, I had no doubt that he would gladly help someone to break the monotony of being Lord Ordacs servant. And it all played out rather suitably if you ask me. The big declaration of love was not something I had counted on, but I didn't find it unlikely once she got there. Bottled up men like Lord Ordac usually go a little off the rails when they experience strong emotions. I think you can rest assured that Mrs Weaver will not try to marry you off with someone for the foreseeable future."

I lay there stunned, and did the only thing I could do. I took Catras hand and pulled her down so I could not only kiss her but have her next to me.

"Miss Greyskull, you are hardly dressed."

"To hell with clothes, Catra!"

"As you wish, Miss Greyskull."

Before I closed the distance between us I asked: "Is my hair really *that* bad?"

"It makes you look like a talkie villain, Miss Greyskull."

"...I will not buy a wig. But I won't go to another hairdresser than my regular one in the future and I will only allow him to remove split ends."

"That is sufficient for me, Miss Greyskull."

And then we melted together.

Well, all that remains is a few footnotes. Teela and Adam's wedding went off without a hitch. They went for their honeymoon in Egypt and will not return until spring. I bet Catra will be over herself when not only Miss Greyskull but Lady Greyskull will be present. I have already booked up Teela on Saturdays for fencing. Uncle Howard married Lady Entrapta in a small ceremony in Westminster Abbey, in front of Newton's tomb. Their honeymoon has to wait until next summer but I have heard that they are indeed going to visit Uppsala University and read some Swedes work, Arrhenius or whatever it was, about that Greenhouse effect. Not my idea of a fun day but what can I say. Scientists. Never imagined Uncle Howard taking interest in the size of cucumbers, but I guess that is what love does to you.

Oh, and one more thing. Four months after the wedding, a package arrived. It was a book, the latest Melwyn Kemppf, fresh from print. It was named "He-Man meets She-Ra, princess of power". I am not sure how his readers will receive it, it is more of a love story than his usual sword-wielding stuff. But I am sure that Catra will enjoy her part as She-ras main antagonist and secret love interest.

The end.

but Catra and Greyskull WILL RETURN.

Some day.

I promise.

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